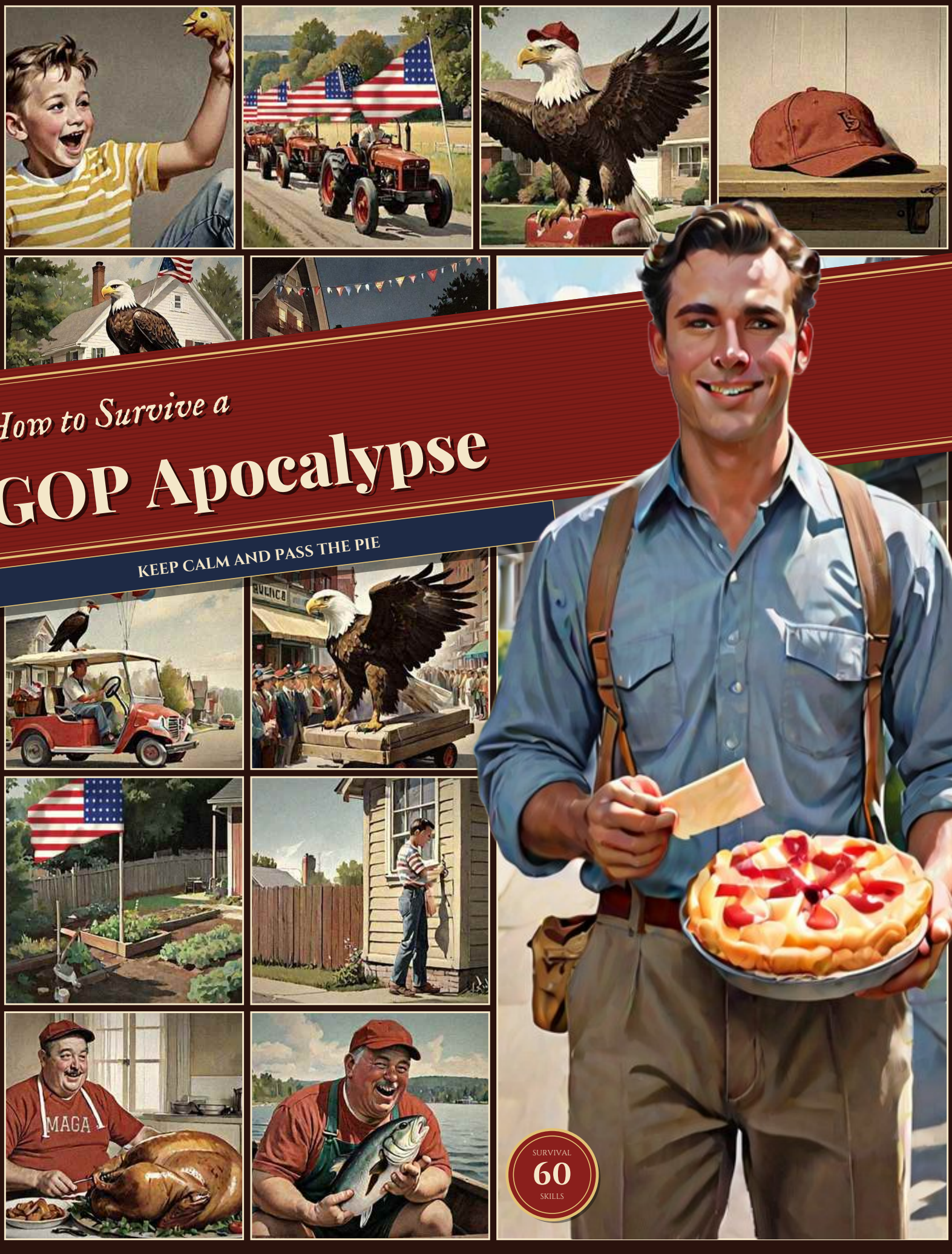

How to Survive a
GOP Apocalypse
KEEP CALM AND PASS THE PIE
MAGA
SURVIVAL
60
SKILLS

HOW TO SURVIVE A GOP APOCALYPSE



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This book belongs to

_____
__

and their survival crew, _____

How to Survive a

GOP APOCALYPSE

60 Essential Skills for the Modern Family in a Land of Red Caps

AN ILLUSTRATED HANDBOOK FOR KEEPING THE PEACE, THE PIE AND YOUR SENSE OF HUMOR

FUN BOOKS · HOME EDITION · 2026

How to Survive a GOP Apocalypse: 60 Essential Skills for the Modern Family in a Land of Red Caps. Fun Books Home Edition, 2026.

Written and illustrated as an original work. The text and pictures in this book were created from scratch for this edition and are not copied from any other publication.

Please read before using this book. This is a work of good-natured humor. Every character, uncle, neighbor and inflatable eagle in it is made up, and any resemblance to your own Uncle Earl is a coincidence (though not a surprising one). The book pokes gentle fun at the gear, the flags and the honking, not at anybody's right to their own opinion. People of every party are welcome at this table, and there is pie for all of them.

Printing tips. This book is laid out on US Letter (8.5 x 11 in) pages. Print double-sided, “flip on long edge”, at 100% scale. For a book that lies flat on the kitchen table, ask a copy shop for spiral or comb binding with a clear front and a heavy back cover.

Made with care for every family that has ever had to seat two uncles at the same Thanksgiving table.

For the neighbor who fixed our gutter,
whatever hat he wears.

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INTRODUCTION

How to use this book

There was a time, not so long ago, when a family could go a whole year without seeing a single red cap. Those days are over. Whether it started with a flag on the house across the street, a boat parade on the lake or a new hat on Grandpa, the GOP apocalypse is here, and it seems to be staying, at least until November.

Most families are not ready. Nobody teaches apocalypse manners in school. Etiquette books say nothing about inflatable eagles. The newspaper only makes it worse. This book is here to help. It gathers everything a sensible American family needs to know to stay calm, stay fed, stay friendly and keep everybody coming back for Thanksgiving.

What you'll find inside. Sixty skills in nine chapters, each on a single page laid out the same way: a picture for every step, a short explanation of why it matters, a materials panel with what you'll need, and a notes panel with tips and the most important warnings. Colored tabs on the edge of every page tell you which chapter you're in, so you can find the right page quickly, even while a truck convoy honks past the window.

How to use it. Don't wait for an emergency. Read the first chapter tonight, before the yard signs bloom. Practice the polite nod in the mirror. Bake a pie and freeze it. Learn three good things to say about the weather. Each skill you practice now is one less argument later.

Start with the basics. If the caps have already arrived, begin with Chapter 1 (the signs), the comfort pantry in Chapter 2, the seating chart in Chapter 4 and changing the subject in Chapter 5. Those four alone will put your household well ahead of the Hendersons, who have been hiding in the basement since the boat parade.

The appendix at the back gathers the charts and checklists you'll reach for most: a field guide to the gear, a family gatherings chart, a list of dinner-table topics that are safe (and not), handy apocalypse conversions, survival-kit checklists, a family survival card, a glossary, and a log for the skills your family has mastered.

A word on kindness. The people in the red caps are your neighbors, your uncles and your grandpa. They shovel your drive, they bring casseroles and they love their country just as you do. This book is about surviving the noise, not the people. Watch for the boxes marked **Important**, and remember that the best tool in any apocalypse is a calm voice and a warm pie.

CHAPTERS AT A GLANCE

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6. Keeping Your Spirits Up	Calm, cheer and a good night's sleep in uncertain times	6
7. Out and About	The diner, the fair, the barbershop and every red cap in between	7
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CHAPTER ONE

1

THE MORNING IT BEGAN

How to recognize the first signs that the red caps have arrived



It usually starts on a Tuesday. The coffee is perking, the radio is playing, and across the street a man you have known for eleven years is hoisting a flag the size of a bedsheet. By lunchtime there are three of them. By supper the mailman is wearing a pin. Do not panic. Millions of American families have woken up in a sea of red caps, and nearly all of them still have their sense of humor. This chapter helps you spot the signs early, stay calm and keep the coffee hot.

IN THIS CHAPTER

01 Spotting the First Red Cap

02 Counting the Flags on Your Street

03 Decoding Bumper Stickers

04 Telling a MAGA Cap from a Baseball Cap

05 Surviving the First Boat Parade

06 Staying Calm When the Neighbor Raises a Flagpole

HOW TO

SPOTTING THE FIRST RED CAP

SKILL 01 · THE MORNING IT BEGAN · 5 MINUTES · EASY

MATERIALS

- Your reading glasses



- A pair of binoculars



- A cup of hot coffee (for the nerves)



- A field guide to hats



- A notepad and pencil



Before you telephone your sister, make sure. Many a father has roused the whole family over what turned out to be a Cardinals fan, a fire hydrant, or a very large tomato. A genuine red cap passes four simple tests.

1



Put On Your Glasses

Most sightings are solved right here. If it is still red and still says something about America, carry on.

2



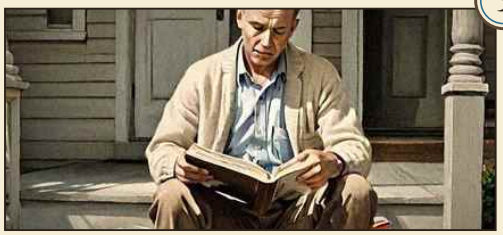
Peek Through the Blinds

Study the hat from indoors. A team cap has a team on it. This one has an opinion.

Check the Field Guide

Compare what you see to the pictures. If it matches the page marked 'Bright Red, Embroidered, Enthusiastic', you have your answer.

3



4



Listen for the Honking

A red cap is rarely alone. If you hear cheerful honking from the road, there are more on the way.

5



Check the Mailbox

Flyers, pamphlets and a free bumper sticker mean the neighborhood is organizing. Do not lick the sticker.

6



Write Down What You See

Note the time, the number of caps and the general mood. You will want this for the family newsletter.

NOTES

If the cap has a cardinal on it, relax. It's just baseball.

IMPORTANT

Never confirm a sighting by asking 'Is that thing serious?' out loud.

HOW TO

COUNTING THE FLAGS ON YOUR STREET

SKILL 02 · THE MORNING IT BEGAN · 20 MINUTES · EASY

Knowing how many flags fly on your street tells you how big the apocalypse is and how many pies you will need for the block party. Children are excellent counters.

1



Start at the Corner

Begin at one end of the street and walk the same side all the way down. No skipping houses.

2



Count the Porch Flags

Make a tick for every flag on a porch. Big ones count twice.

3



Count the Truck Flags

Pickup trucks often carry two or three flags each. Count them while the truck is parked.

MATERIALS



A clipboard and pencil



A pair of binoculars



A red crayon



A comfortable pair of sneakers



A lemonade for the road

4



Look Up at the Flagpoles

Some neighbors fly their flag thirty feet up. Tip your head back and keep counting.

5



Color In the Map

Use the red crayon to color each house on your map. Soon you will have a very red map.

NOTES

Wave at everyone as you go. A friendly counter is never chased off a lawn.



6 ### *Report to the Family*

Read out the total at supper. Father will want to sit down first.

HOW TO

DECODING BUMPER STICKERS

SKILL 03 · THE MORNING IT BEGAN · 10 MINUTES · EASY

MATERIALS

- A magnifying glass



- A notebook



- A flashlight (for night reading)



- Good manners



- Sunglasses



A bumper is a car's way of telling you how it feels. Learning to read stickers lets you know who you are parked next to before you open your door into theirs.

1



Approach From Behind

Walk to the back of the parked car slowly. Never read a bumper while it is moving.

2



Count the Stickers

One sticker is a hint. Six stickers is a lifestyle.

Read the Big Words First

The biggest letters tell you the main idea. It is usually 'Great' or 'Again'.

3



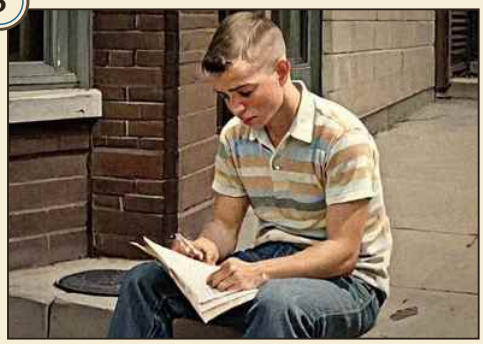
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Look for the Little Eagles

Eagles, flags and stars are common decorations. A cartoon eagle wearing sunglasses means a fun owner.

5



Write Down the Best Ones

Keep a list. Some of them rhyme.

6



Step Back Before the Owner Returns

Walk away whistling. If the owner comes back, compliment the hubcaps.

NOTES

A sticker that says 'Honk if you agree' should not be honked at by accident.

HOW TO

TELLING A MAGA CAP FROM A BASEBALL CAP

SKILL 04 · THE MORNING IT BEGAN · 5 MINUTES · MEDIUM

Red caps are everywhere, and not all of them are political. Some belong to the Little League, some to the gas station, and one belongs to your son. Here is how to tell.

1



Check the Front

A baseball cap has a team. A MAGA cap has four white words and no team at all.

2



Count the Words

Make America Great Again is four words. 'Reds' is one. Count carefully.

3



Feel the Embroidery

The real thing has thick, raised white letters. Run a finger across and you will know.

MATERIALS


The family's own baseball caps


A good lamp


Your reading glasses


A lint brush


A hat rack

4



Look at the Wearer

A MAGA cap usually comes with a matching shirt, a pin and a very good mood.

5



Sort the Family Caps

Hang team caps on the left hook and anything with an opinion on the right.

NOTES

When in doubt, read the back. Some caps say 'Again' on the back too, just to be sure.



6 *Return Borrowed Caps*

If one of the caps is not yours, wash it gently and return it with a smile and a muffin.

HOW TO

SURVIVING THE FIRST BOAT PARADE

SKILL 05 · THE MORNING IT BEGAN · 1 AFTERNOON · MEDIUM

On summer weekends the lake fills with motorboats flying enormous flags, all honking at once. It is loud, it is wet, and it is surprisingly well organized.

MATERIALS

- A folding lawn chair



- Cotton wool for the ears



- A big sun hat



- A thermos of iced tea



- A towel (for the wake)



1



Pick a Spot Up the Bank

Sit well back from the water. The wake from forty boats can reach the picnic table.

2



Plug Your Ears

The horns start all at once. A wad of cotton in each ear keeps the hearing aid happy.

3

Watch the Flags Go By

Count them if you like. Most people give up after two hundred.



4



Wave When Waved At

Someone will wave. Waving back is polite and costs nothing.

5



Dry Off After the Wake

The big boats make big waves. Keep a towel handy.

6



Pour Yourself Some Tea

When the last boat honks by, enjoy the quiet. It lasts about twenty minutes.

NOTES

Bring a pair of binoculars. Some of the boats have cardboard eagles on the bow.

IMPORTANT

Do not try to join the parade in a rowboat. You will be swamped, cheerfully.

HOW TO

STAYING CALM WHEN THE NEIGHBOR RAISES A FLAGPOLE

SKILL 06 · THE MORNING IT BEGAN · 1 MORNING · MEDIUM

One Saturday you will hear digging. By noon your neighbor will have a forty-foot flagpole, a flag that blocks the sun, and a very proud expression.

1



Hear the Digging

A deep hole in the neighbor's yard on a Saturday morning means a pole is coming.

2



Watch It Go Up

Stand at your window and sip your tea. There is nothing to be done now.

3



Measure the Shadow

Find out where the shade lands. You may need to move the tomatoes.

MATERIALS



A cup of chamomile tea



Sunglasses (for the glare)



A garden chair



A plate of cookies



A tape measure

4



Admire the Craftsmanship

Say something nice. 'That's a straight pole' is true and friendly.

5



Take Over the Cookies

Nothing builds a fence between neighbors like silence. Nothing knocks it down like cookies.



6 *Enjoy the Free Shade*

On hot afternoons the flag shades half your yard. Put a chair under it.

NOTES

Ask if it lights up at night. If it does, buy thicker curtains.

CHAPTER TWO

2

THE HOME FRONT

Getting your house ready to ride it out in comfort







Every sensible family keeps a stocked pantry, a flashlight that works and a quiet place to sit. In a GOP apocalypse you will want all three, plus a lot more pie. This chapter turns an ordinary house into a cozy shelter where the radio plays only ball games, the curtains are thick, and the cookie jar never, ever runs out.

IN THIS CHAPTER

07 Stocking the Comfort Pantry
08 Turning the Rec Room into a Bunker
09 Soundproofing Against the Neighbor's Loudspeaker
10 Reading the Morning Paper Safely
11 Baking Emergency Pie
12 Making a Calm-Down Corner
13 Hanging Curtains Thick Enough
14 Growing a Privacy Hedge

HOW TO

STOCKING THE COMFORT PANTRY

SKILL 07 · THE HOME FRONT · 1 AFTERNOON · EASY

An apocalypse is no time to run out of cocoa. A comfort pantry holds everything a family needs to stay cheerful for a long, loud election season.

1



Clear a Shelf

Empty one whole shelf. This is the comfort shelf, and nobody touches it without a good reason.

2



Stack the Cocoa

Cocoa goes on the front row where you can reach it in the dark.

3

Add the Jam

Strawberry, grape and apricot. Variety keeps spirits high.



4



Fill the Cookie Tin

Bake a double batch. Then bake another, because the first one will vanish.

5



Write the List

Pin a list to the door so you know when things run low. Things will run low.

6



Close the Door and Smile

Knowing the pantry is full is half of surviving anything.

NOTES

Hide one emergency chocolate bar behind the flour. Tell no one.

MATERIALS

- Cocoa and marshmallows



- Twelve boxes of crackers



- Jars of jam



- A big tin of cookies



- A pantry list on a clipboard



HOW TO

TURNING THE REC ROOM INTO A BUNKER

SKILL 08 · THE HOME FRONT · 1 WEEKEND · MEDIUM

Every house has a basement or a back room. With a few cushions, a card table and a good lamp, it becomes the coziest bunker on the block.

MATERIALS


A card table


Lots of cushions


A good reading lamp


A shelf of board games


A radio that only gets ball games

1



Clear Out the Junk

Haul out the broken lamp and Grandma's old exercise machine. A bunker needs room.

2



Lay Down a Rug

A braided rug makes any concrete floor feel like home.

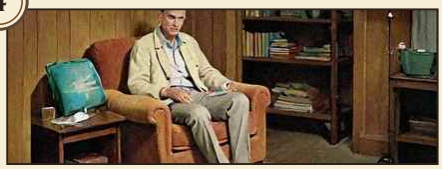
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Set Up the Card Table

This is where the family will play rummy until things calm down.

4



Pile the Cushions

Cushions on every chair and a few spare on the floor. Comfort is the whole point.

5



Tune the Radio

Find the ball game and leave it there. Tape the dial if you have to.



6 *Hang a Sign*

A sign on the door that says 'Politics-Free Zone' lets everyone know the rules.

NOTES

Keep the bunker stocked with crossword puzzles. They are very calming.

HOW TO

SOUNDPROOFING AGAINST THE NEIGHBOR'S LOUDSPEAKER

SKILL 09 · THE HOME FRONT · 1 AFTERNOON · MEDIUM

Some neighbors like to share their favorite speeches with the whole street at full volume. A few old blankets and some clever thinking bring back the peace.

1



Find the Noisy Wall

Walk around the house and listen. The noise usually comes in through the side facing the neighbor.

2



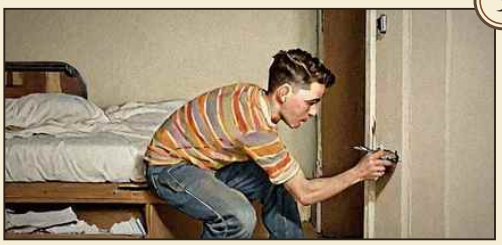
Collect Egg Cartons

Ask everyone on the street for empty egg cartons. Even the neighbor might give you some.

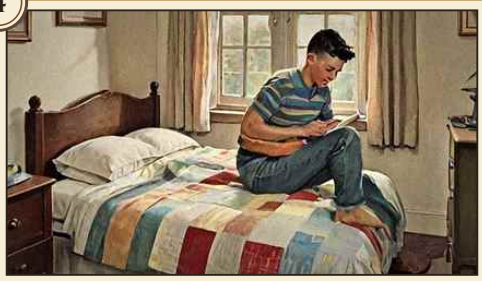
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Tack Them Up

Egg cartons on the wall soak up sound. They also look like a very odd art project.



4



Hang a Quilt

Hang a heavy quilt over the window. Grandma's wedding quilt is too nice; use the camping one.

5



Play Something Sweeter

Put on a record of your own. Bing Crosby beats a loudspeaker every time.

6



Wear the Earmuffs

If all else fails, earmuffs. They are warm in winter, too.

NOTES

Speeches usually end at suppertime. Plan quiet activities for after.

MATERIALS

- Old quilts and blankets



- Egg cartons (lots)



- A hammer and tacks



- Earmuffs



- A record player and soft music



HOW TO

READING THE MORNING PAPER SAFELY

SKILL 10 · THE HOME FRONT · 15 MINUTES · MEDIUM

The morning newspaper can be hard on the nerves. With the right order and a steady cup of coffee, any father can get through it before work.

MATERIALS


The morning newspaper

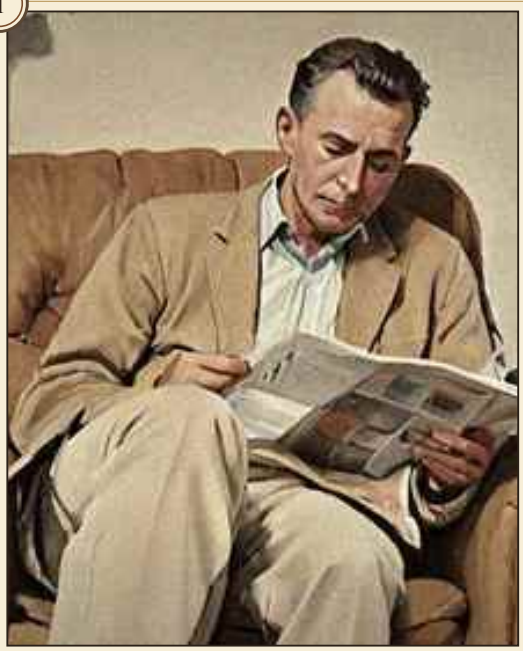

A strong cup of coffee


A comfortable armchair


Scissors (for the comics)


A fresh doughnut

1



Sit Down First

Never read the front page standing up. Find your chair.

2



Start With the Comics

Begin with something cheerful. Dagwood is always having a worse day than you.

3



Then the Sports Page

A box score is very soothing. Numbers do not shout.

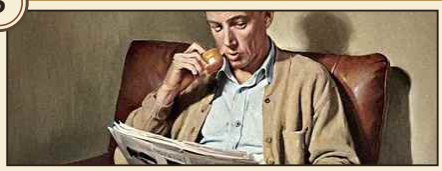
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Peek at the Front Page

Fold the front page in half and read only the top. You can always read more tomorrow.

5



Eat the Doughnut

This is what the doughnut is for.



6 ### *Clip a Coupon and Move On*

End on something useful. Ten cents off soap is a victory.

NOTES

If the headline has an exclamation point, save it for after lunch.

HOW TO

BAKING EMERGENCY PIE

SKILL 11 · THE HOME FRONT · 2 HOURS · MEDIUM

Pie solves more problems than any committee. Keep the makings for an emergency pie on hand at all times, for hard days, sad days, and any day the uncles visit.

MATERIALS

- Flour, butter and salt



- Six tart apples



- Sugar and cinnamon



- A rolling pin



- A good pie tin



1



Make the Crust

Cut cold butter into flour until it looks like crumbs. Add ice water a spoonful at a time.

2



Roll It Out

Roll from the middle out. A few cracks are fine; nobody is judging.

3

Slice the Apples

Thin slices, tossed with sugar and cinnamon. The kitchen will already smell better.



4



Fill and Crimp

Pile in the apples, lay on the top crust and pinch the edges all the way round.

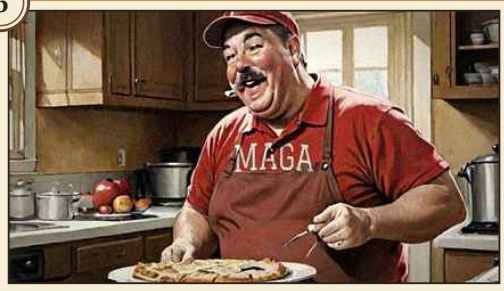
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Bake Until Golden

About fifty minutes. Open the window so the neighbors can smell it too.

6



Cut a Slice for Everybody

Pie is the great peacemaker. Everyone gets a slice, whatever hat they wear.

NOTES

A slice of pie handed over the fence has ended more feuds than any speech.

HOW TO

MAKING A CALM-DOWN CORNER

SKILL 12 · THE HOME FRONT · 1 HOUR · EASY

Every home needs one quiet spot where nobody talks politics and everybody gets a cushion. Children are very good at building them.

MATERIALS


A beanbag or big cushion


A soft blanket


A stack of picture books


A box of crayons


A goldfish in a bowl

1



Pick a Quiet Spot

Under the stairs or by a sunny window works well.

2



Bring a Cushion

The biggest, softest one in the house.

3



Add a Blanket

For wrapping up in when the news is on in the other room.

4



Stack the Books

Picture books only. Nothing with a headline.

5



Add the Goldfish

Watching a goldfish is the calmest thing a person can do.



6 *Invite the Family*

Anyone may use it, as long as they take their hat off first.

NOTES

Put a little 'Shh' sign over the door. Even uncles respect a sign.

HOW TO

HANGING CURTAINS THICK ENOUGH

SKILL 13 · THE HOME FRONT · 1 AFTERNOON · MEDIUM

Some neighbors leave their light-up flag on all night. Heavy curtains keep the bedroom dark and the family rested.

1



Measure the Window

Measure wide and long. Glare sneaks around the edges.

2



Choose the Fabric

The thicker the better. Dark green velvet is both handsome and glare-proof.

3

Sew the Hems

Run the fabric through the machine. Double hems for extra weight.



4



Put Up the Rod

Climb the stepladder carefully and fix the rod well above the window.

5



Hang the Curtains

Slide them on and draw them shut.

6



Test at Night

Turn off the lamp. If you cannot see the flag glowing, you have done it.

NOTES

Leave a tiny gap at the top. A little light helps you find your slippers.

MATERIALS

- Heavy velvet fabric



- A sewing machine



- Curtain rods



- A stepladder



- A measuring tape



HOW TO

GROWING A PRIVACY HEDGE

SKILL 14 · THE HOME FRONT · 1 SEASON · MEDIUM

Good fences make good neighbors, but a good hedge makes them even better. In two summers you will see green leaves instead of red banners.

MATERIALS


Privet or arborvitae plants


A spade


A watering can


Garden gloves


Hedge clippers

1



Mark the Line

Run a string along the edge of the yard where the hedge will go.

2



Dig the Holes

One hole every two feet. Grandmothers may assign this step to a grandson.

3



Plant the Shrubs

Set each one in, fill the soil back and press it down firmly.

4



Water Every Day

A new hedge is thirsty. Water it every evening the first summer.

5



Wait Patiently

Hedges are slow. Knit a sweater while you wait.



6 *Trim It Tall*

In two years it will be taller than any yard sign. Trim the top flat and admire it.

NOTES

Plant a few rose bushes in front. A hedge with roses looks friendly, not grumpy.

CHAPTER THREE

3

LIFE ON OUR STREET

Getting along with the neighbors when the neighbors are all wearing red







The neighbors have not changed, not really. Mr. Dawson still mows his lawn on Saturday at seven. Mrs. Pike still brings round a casserole when someone is ill. They just do it now in red caps, under a flag, with a pin that says something about winning. This chapter keeps the street friendly, the sugar borrowed and the lawns mowed, whatever the signs say.

IN THIS CHAPTER

15 Borrowing Sugar from the MAGA Neighbor
16 Surviving the Lawn Sign Race
17 Watching the Golf Cart Parade
18 Admiring the Neighbor's Patriotic Mailbox
19 Enjoying the Block Party
20 Surviving the Homeowners' Meeting
21 Waving Back at the Truck Convoy

HOW TO

BORROWING SUGAR FROM THE MAGA NEIGHBOR

SKILL 15 · LIFE ON OUR STREET · 10 MINUTES · EASY

Running out of sugar is the oldest excuse in the world to go next door. It still works, and it is a fine way to remember that the man in the red cap is still the man who fixed your gutter.

MATERIALS

- An empty measuring cup



- Your best smile



- A promise to return it



- A jar of jam (as thanks)



- A clean apron



1



Knock Politely

Three knocks, not four. Step back from the door so he can see it's you.

2



Say Good Morning

He will be wearing his cap. He is always wearing his cap.

3

Ask for a Cup

Hold up your measuring cup and ask nicely. Most neighbors cannot resist a measuring cup.



4



Admire His Porch

Find one nice thing to say. The geraniums are lovely.

5



Say Thank You

Thank him and promise to bring something back.

6



Return It With Jam

Bring the cup back full, with a jar of jam on top. That is how good streets work.

NOTES

If he asks you to sign something, say you left your pen at home.

HOW TO

SURVIVING THE LAWN SIGN RACE

SKILL 16 · LIFE ON OUR STREET · 1 SEASON · MEDIUM

First one sign appears. Then two. Then the whole lawn across the street is a forest of red, white and blue. You do not have to win. You just have to keep mowing.

1



Count the Signs

Look across the street and count. Then stop counting; it won't help.

2



Mow Your Own Lawn

Keep your own grass neat. A tidy lawn is its own message.

3



Plant Some Flowers

Instead of signs, plant petunias. Nobody argues with petunias.

MATERIALS



A lawn mower



A wheelbarrow of flowers



A garden gnome (optional)



A thermos of lemonade



A good sense of humor

4



Add a Gnome

A garden gnome is the only lawn ornament both parties like.

5



Wave Across the Street

When the neighbor puts up sign number thirty, wave and smile.

NOTES

Sign season ends in November. Petunias last all summer.



6 ### *Enjoy Your Lemonade*

Sit on the porch and admire your flowers. You have the nicest yard on the block.

HOW TO

WATCHING THE GOLF CART PARADE

SKILL 17 · LIFE ON OUR STREET · 1 HOUR · EASY

MATERIALS

- A lawn chair by the curb



- A small flag to wave



- Popcorn



- A sun hat



- Patience



In some neighborhoods the parade comes by golf cart, decorated with streamers, flags and a cardboard eagle. It moves at four miles an hour, so there is plenty of time to wave.

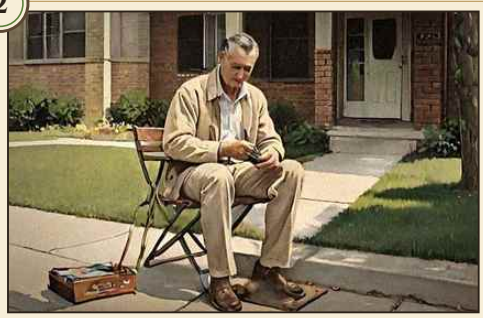
1



Hear It Coming

Golf carts hum, and their drivers honk little horns. You will hear them three streets away.

2



Set Up Your Chair

Put your lawn chair on the curb. You will be here a while.

3

Admire the Decorations

Each cart is decorated differently. Some have balloons. One has a stuffed bald eagle.



4



Wave as They Pass

They are going slowly enough to wave at each one personally.

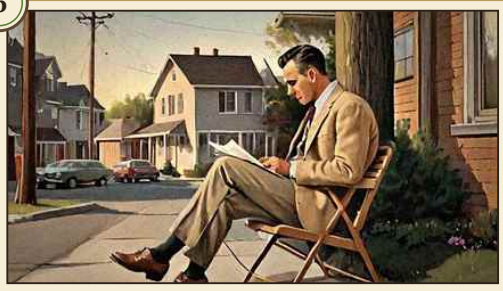
5



Offer Popcorn

Hold out the bowl. Parade drivers get hungry.

6



Fold Up Your Chair

When the last cart has hummed by, fold your chair and go in for supper.

NOTES

If one cart breaks down in front of your house, offer a push. It is very light.

HOW TO

ADMIRING THE NEIGHBOR'S PATRIOTIC MAILBOX

SKILL 18 · LIFE ON OUR STREET · 10 MINUTES · EASY

One morning the neighbor's plain mailbox will be painted red, white and blue, with stars, stripes and a small eagle on top. He will want you to notice.

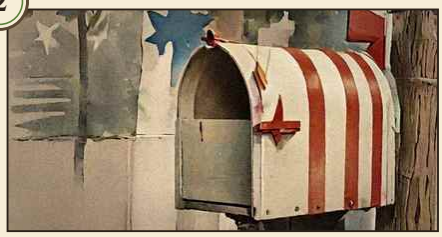
1



Notice It

It will be hard to miss. It may also be shaped like a tiny barn.

2



Look Closely

Find the little details. There is usually a tiny painted cap.

3



Compliment the Paint Job

Brush strokes this straight deserve a compliment.

MATERIALS


Your reading glasses


A kind word


A flashlight (it lights up)


A camera


Your own plain mailbox

4



Take His Picture

He will want a photograph for the family album.

5



Check Your Own Mailbox

Look at your own plain gray box. It does its job. That is enough.

NOTES

If he offers to paint yours too, say you are waiting for the color to come back into style.



6 *Get Your Mail*

Pick up your mail. His mailbox gets the same mail as yours; remember that.

HOW TO

ENJOYING THE BLOCK PARTY

SKILL 19 · LIFE ON OUR STREET · 1 AFTERNOON · EASY

The block party goes on, as it always has. There are hot dogs, a sack race and a giant inflatable eagle in a red cap. Children love it.

MATERIALS

- A covered dish



- Your sneakers (for the sack race)



- A folding chair



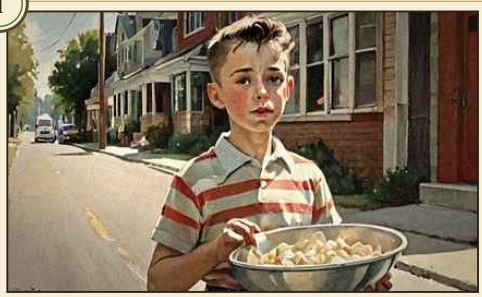
- A big appetite



- A handkerchief for mustard



1



Bring a Dish

Everybody brings something. Potato salad is always welcome.

2



Find the Hot Dogs

Follow the smoke. Whoever is grilling will be wearing a red apron and a red cap.

3

Gaze at the Eagle

A twenty-foot inflatable eagle is something to see. Stand back; it sways.



4



Run the Sack Race

Politics does not matter in a sack race. Only hopping matters.

5



Eat Too Much

That is what block parties are for.

6



Help Clean Up

Pick up the paper plates. Neighbors remember who helped.

NOTES

The eagle is deflated at dusk. It is the saddest and funniest thing you will ever see.

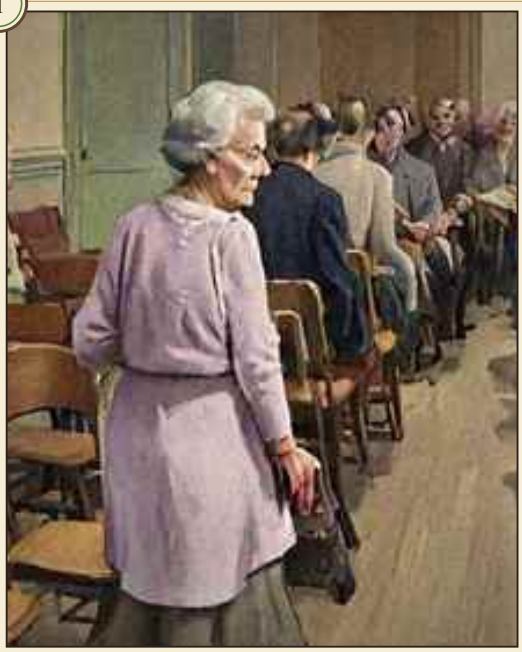
HOW TO

SURVIVING THE HOMEOWNERS' MEETING

SKILL 20 · LIFE ON OUR STREET · 1 EVENING · HARD

Once a month the homeowners' association meets in the church hall to discuss hedges, parking and whether flagpoles can be taller than houses. Bring knitting.

1



Arrive Early

The good chairs at the back go first.

2



Bring Your Cushion

Folding chairs are hard. Meetings are long.

3



Start Knitting

Knitting keeps your hands busy and your mouth closed.

MATERIALS



Your knitting



A thermos of coffee



A cushion for the folding chair



Reading glasses



A plate of brownies

4



Listen to the Flagpole Debate

There will be a debate about flagpoles. Knit faster.

5



Raise Your Hand Once

Ask one sensible question, about the potholes. Everyone agrees about potholes.

NOTES

The meeting ends when the brownies are gone. Bring a small plate if you want to go home early.



6 *Pass the Brownies*

End the meeting by passing round a plate. Every vote goes better with chocolate.

HOW TO

WAVING BACK AT THE TRUCK CONVOY

SKILL 21 · LIFE ON OUR STREET · 15 MINUTES · EASY

MATERIALS

- A small American flag



- Earmuffs



- A sun hat



- A spot on the front steps

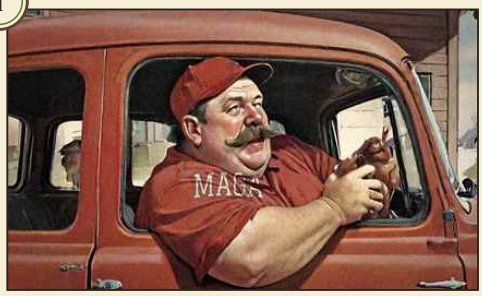


- A glass of milk



On Saturday mornings a line of pickup trucks drives through town, each one flying flags from every corner and honking a happy tune. It is loud, but it is also a parade.

1



Hear the Honking

When you hear horns from the highway, they are coming.

2



Put On the Earmuffs

Thirty trucks honking is a lot of trucks honking.

3

Count the Trucks

Count them as they go by. Count the flags too, if you are good at math.



4



Wave Your Flag

Everyone likes the American flag. Wave it high.

5



Watch the Last One

The last truck always has the biggest flag.

6



Drink Your Milk

When it's quiet again, finish your milk and go play.

NOTES

Truck drivers love it when children wave. Some honk back twice.

CHAPTER FOUR

4

FAMILY GATHERINGS

Thanksgiving, Christmas and every Sunday supper in between







You can choose your friends, but you cannot choose who turns up to Thanksgiving in a red cap carrying a casserole and a strong opinion. Family is family. Uncle Earl still carves the best turkey in three counties, and Grandpa still slips the children a quarter. This chapter gets everyone through the holidays fed, seated and, most importantly, still speaking.

IN THIS CHAPTER

22 Thanksgiving with Uncle Earl
23 When Grandpa Gets a New Red Cap
24 Surviving the Christmas Sweater Swap
25 Seating the Holiday Table
26 The Family Party-Line Telephone Call
27 Explaining It to the Children

HOW TO

THANKSGIVING WITH UNCLE EARL

SKILL 22 · FAMILY GATHERINGS · 1 LONG DAY · HARD

Uncle Earl arrives at noon in his red cap, his red shirt and a cardigan covered in pins. He is loud, he is kind and he brings the best sweet potatoes you will ever eat. Here is how to enjoy him.

MATERIALS


A very large turkey

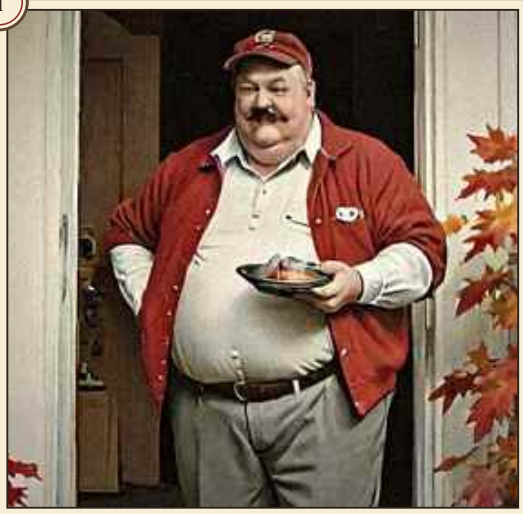

Extra chairs


A second pie (for emergencies)


A football game on the radio


A seating chart

1



Greet Him at the Door

Big smile, big hug. Take his coat. Leave him the cap; he won't give it up anyway.

2



Praise the Sweet Potatoes

They are very good sweet potatoes. Say so, early and often.

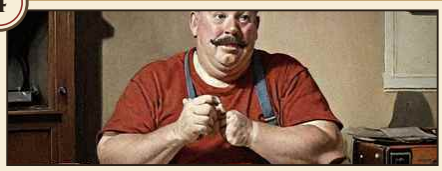
3



Give Him the Carving Knife

A man with a job is a man too busy to start a debate.

4



Steer Talk to Football

The game is on. Ask him who will win. He will know.

5



Serve Pie Promptly

When the conversation turns, the pie comes out. Timing is everything.



6 ### *Pack Him Leftovers*

Send him home with a plate. It is the best goodbye there is.

NOTES

Seat Uncle Earl next to the person who talks least. Everyone will have a lovely time.

IMPORTANT

Never say 'Well, actually' at Thanksgiving. It has started more arguments than any other two words.

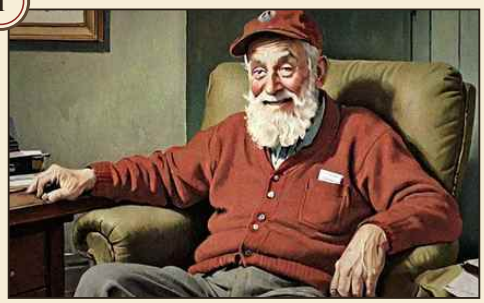
HOW TO

WHEN GRANDPA GETS A NEW RED CAP

SKILL 23 · FAMILY GATHERINGS · 1 AFTERNOON · EASY

Grandpa has worn the same brown fedora for thirty years. One Sunday he turns up in a bright red cap and refuses to take it off, even indoors, even at church. Love him anyway.

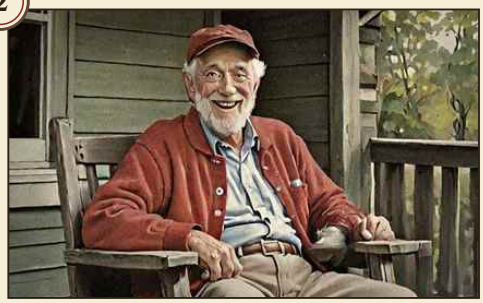
1



Notice It Kindly

Say 'New hat, Grandpa?' and nothing else. He has been waiting for someone to ask.

2



Let Him Tell the Story

He will explain where he got it. It will take a while. Listen anyway.

3

Remember the Fedora

The fedora is in the hall closet. Do not mention it yet.



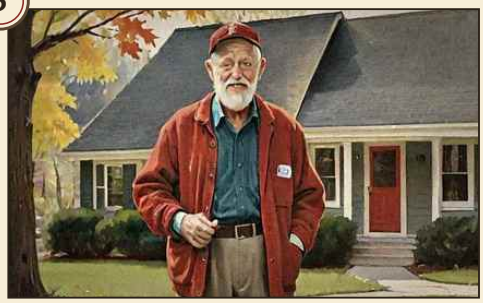
4



Play Checkers

Grandpa is still the best checkers player in the family, cap or no cap.

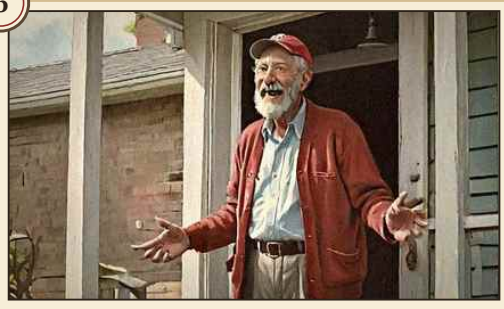
5



Take His Picture

He will want to send it to his friends at the barbershop.

6



Give Him a Hug

Grandpas are for hugging. Red cap and all.

NOTES

On his birthday, give him a new fedora. Sometimes he wears it. Sometimes over the cap.

MATERIALS

- A cup of coffee for Grandpa



- His favorite cookies



- A checkerboard



- A camera



- Your patience



HOW TO

SURVIVING THE CHRISTMAS SWEATER SWAP

SKILL 24 · FAMILY GATHERINGS · 1 EVENING · MEDIUM

Aunt Darlene knits everyone a sweater every Christmas. This year they are bright red, with white letters across the front and an eagle on the back. Wear it with pride, for one evening.

MATERIALS


A wrapped present for Aunt Darlene


A big smile


A camera


Eggnog


A coat to wear on the way home

1



Open It Slowly

Unwrap the present carefully. You have a few seconds to prepare your face.

2



Hold It Up

Hold it against yourself and say 'Oh my!' This is true and polite.

3



Thank Her Warmly

She knitted for three months. Thank her for every one of them.

4



Put It On

Wear it for the family photo. It is very warm.

5



Drink Some Eggnog

Eggnog makes any sweater look better.



6 *Wear Your Coat Home*

Button your coat on the way home. All the way up.

NOTES

Keep the sweater. It makes a fine dog blanket by February.

HOW TO

SEATING THE HOLIDAY TABLE

SKILL 25 · FAMILY GATHERINGS · 1 HOUR · HARD

Where people sit decides how dinner goes. A clever seating chart is the most powerful tool a hostess has. Plan it like a general.

1



Make the List

Write down everybody who is coming, and who has argued with whom since 1952.

2



Draw the Table

Sketch the table on paper. Mark the chairs nearest the kitchen; those are for escapes.

3

Separate the Talkers

Put the loudest uncle at the far end, the quiet aunt in the middle and the children as a buffer.



4



Write the Place Cards

Neat handwriting makes it official. Nobody swaps a nice place card.

5



Build a Tall Centerpiece

A tall centerpiece blocks eye contact. Use lots of flowers.

6



Stand Back and Admire

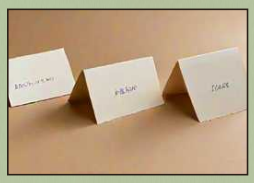
Your table is set and so is the peace.

NOTES

Seat yourself nearest the kitchen. The hostess can always go and check on the gravy.

MATERIALS

- Place cards



- A fountain pen



- The good tablecloth



- A big centerpiece



- A list of who disagrees with whom



HOW TO

THE FAMILY PARTY-LINE TELEPHONE CALL

SKILL 26 · FAMILY GATHERINGS · 30 MINUTES · MEDIUM

On Sunday evenings the whole family telephones at once. Everyone talks, nobody listens, and Uncle Earl gets on the line from his workshop. A father needs a plan.

MATERIALS


A comfortable chair by the telephone

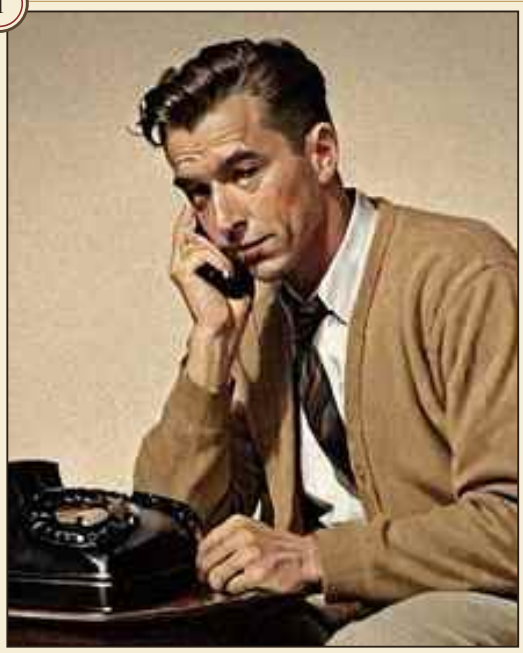

A cup of coffee


A notepad


A crossword puzzle


A kitchen timer

1



Sit Down by the Phone

Get comfortable. These calls are never short.

2



Say Hello to Everyone

Greet each person by name. It takes a minute but it counts.

3



Hold the Receiver Away

When the uncles get going, hold the phone a foot from your ear.

4



Do the Crossword

Nod along while you finish 14 Across. 'Mm-hm' fits most conversations.

5



Set the Timer

When the kitchen timer rings, it is time to 'check on the roast'.



6 ### *Say Goodbye Warmly*

End with 'Love you all, see you at Easter.' Hang up gently.

NOTES

The roast excuse works every week. Nobody has ever checked whether you actually have a roast.

HOW TO

EXPLAINING IT TO THE CHILDREN

SKILL 27 · FAMILY GATHERINGS · 15 MINUTES · MEDIUM

Sooner or later a child will ask why Uncle Earl wears his hat at the table. Children deserve an honest, gentle answer, and maybe a cookie.

1



Sit Down Together

Find a quiet spot and sit at their level.

2



Listen to the Question

Let them ask it their way. They usually ask something simpler than you expect.

3

Explain Simply

Say that grown-ups have different ideas about running the country, and that's allowed.



4



Talk About What We Share

Everybody in the family loves pie, baseball and the Fourth of July.

5



Share the Cookies

Every hard talk should end with a cookie.

6



Give a Hug

And then a hug, and then go play.

NOTES

Children who see grown-ups disagree kindly learn the most important lesson of all.

MATERIALS

- A plate of cookies



- Two glasses of milk



- A quiet spot



- A picture book about America



- A good hug



CHAPTER FIVE

5

TALKING WITHOUT FIGHTING

The fine old art of conversation, and changing the subject







Our grandparents knew how to talk about the weather for an hour. It was not because they were dull. It was because they were wise. In a GOP apocalypse every conversation is a short walk from a long argument, and a sensible family needs a few tricks to stay on the safe path. Here they are: the nod, the weather, the pie, and the graceful exit.

IN THIS CHAPTER

28 Changing the Subject to the Weather
29 Mastering the Polite Nod
30 Finding Common Ground
31 Answering Aunt Darlene's Chain Letter
32 Riding Along with Talk Radio
33 Agreeing to Disagree
34 Ending a Conversation Gracefully

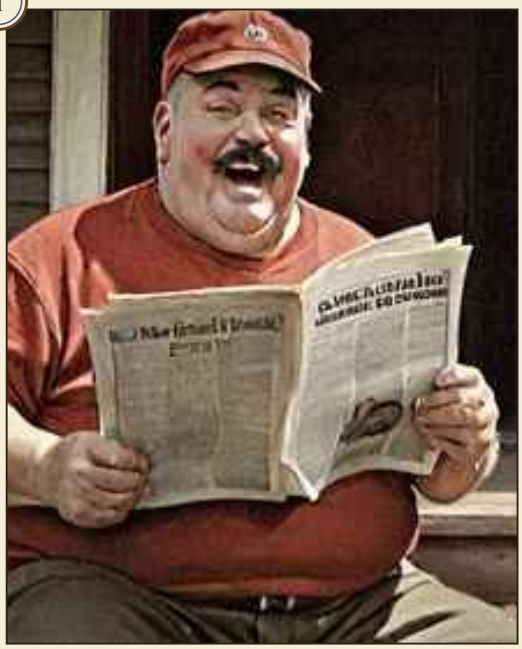
HOW TO

CHANGING THE SUBJECT TO THE WEATHER

SKILL 28 · TALKING WITHOUT FIGHTING · 1 MINUTE · EASY

The weather is the oldest safe subject in the world. It affects everybody equally, it changes every day, and nobody can be blamed for it. Well, almost nobody.

1



Spot the Turn

When the talk turns to Washington, you have about four seconds.

2



Look at the Sky

Look up thoughtfully and say 'Looks like rain'. Everyone will look up too.

3



Tap the Barometer

A tap on the barometer gives the move some authority.

MATERIALS


An almanac


A barometer


A thermometer by the door


A comfortable porch


An umbrella

4



Check the Almanac

Read out the long-range forecast. It takes a while.

5



Discuss Last Winter

Everyone remembers last winter. Everyone has a story about it.

NOTES

Sunsets work almost as well as weather. Point at one and sigh.



6 *Open the Umbrella*

If it actually rains, you have won.

HOW TO

MASTERING THE POLITE NOD

SKILL 29 · TALKING WITHOUT FIGHTING · 5 MINUTES · MEDIUM

The polite nod says 'I hear you' without saying 'I agree'. It is the most useful gesture in the American home and takes only a little practice.

MATERIALS

- A hand mirror



- A cup of tea



- A pleasant expression



- A quiet afternoon to practice



- A cardigan



1



Practice in the Mirror

Nod slowly, once. Not too deep. Not too fast.

2



Add a Small Smile

A tiny smile keeps the nod friendly. A big smile looks like agreement.

Hum Along

A soft 'Mm' with the nod is good. 'Mm-hm' is better.

3



4



Sip Your Tea

When you need a break from nodding, sip your tea.

5



Never Nod Twice

Two nods means yes. Be careful.

6



Use It at the Party

Now try it on the uncle. He will feel heard. You will feel fine.

NOTES

Practice on the dog first. Dogs never argue.

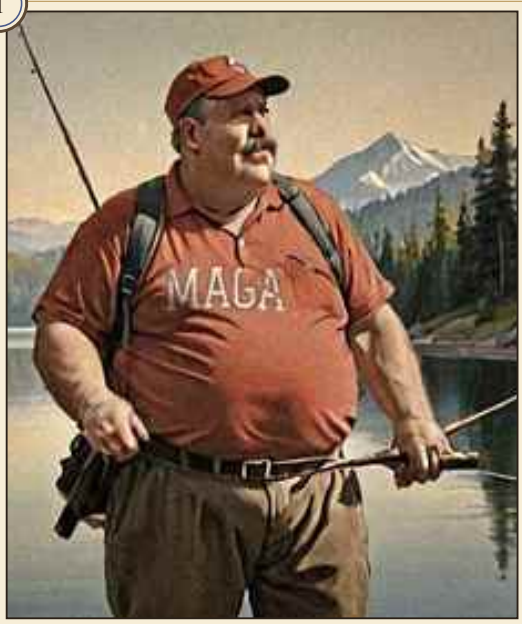
HOW TO

FINDING COMMON GROUND

SKILL 30 · TALKING WITHOUT FIGHTING · 1 AFTERNOON · MEDIUM

Under the cap, Uncle Earl loves exactly what you love: fishing, apple pie, the grandchildren and a quiet lake at dawn. Find the common ground and stand on it.

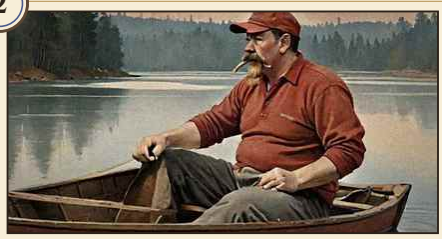
1



Invite Him Fishing

Nobody argues in a rowboat. They might tip it over.

2



Row Out Quietly

The lake is still. So, for once, is Uncle Earl.

3



Bait the Hooks

Let him show you how. He likes showing people how.

MATERIALS


Two fishing poles


A tin of worms


A thermos of coffee


A lunch pail


A rowboat

4



Wait for a Bite

Fishing is mostly waiting. Waiting is mostly peaceful.

5

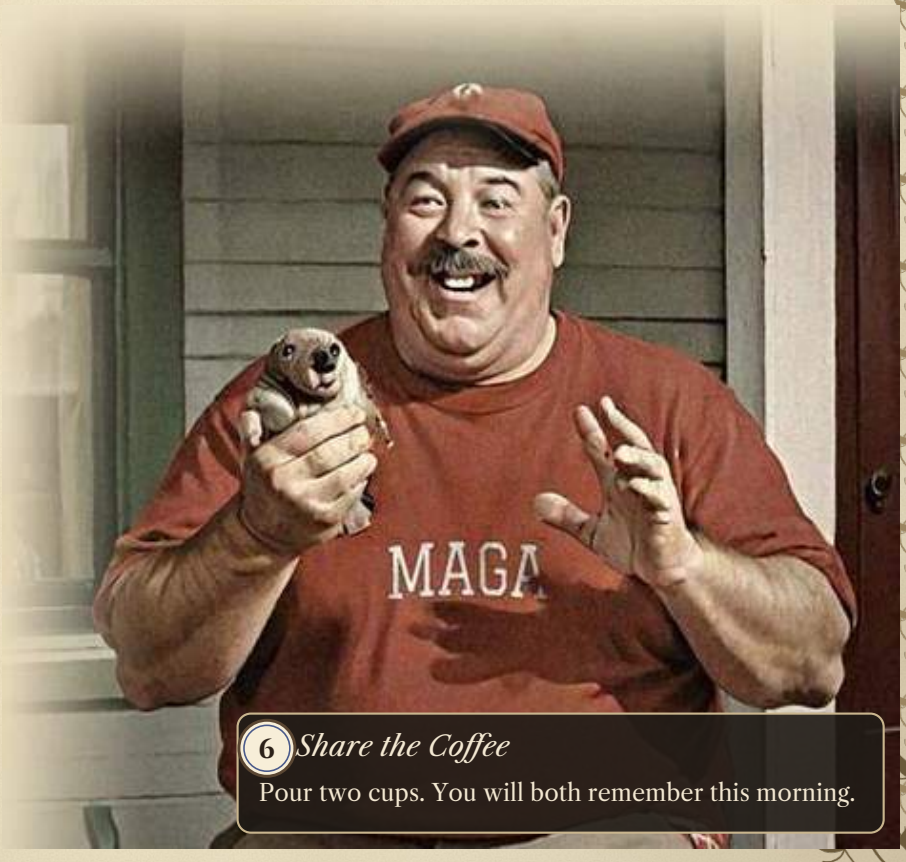


Admire His Catch

When he lands a bass, whoop like you mean it.

NOTES

Fishing, bowling, gardening and grandchildren are all common ground. Collect them.



6 *Share the Coffee*

Pour two cups. You will both remember this morning.

HOW TO

ANSWERING AUNT DARLENE'S CHAIN LETTER

SKILL 31 · TALKING WITHOUT FIGHTING · 20 MINUTES · MEDIUM

MATERIALS

- Good writing paper



- A fountain pen



- Envelopes and stamps



- A favorite recipe card



- A pressed flower



Aunt Darlene writes chain letters. Each one says to copy it ten times or something dreadful will happen to the country. Answer with love and a recipe.

1



Open the Letter

There will be capital letters and many exclamation points. Brace yourself.

2



Read It Once

Read it once, then set it down. Twice is not necessary.

3

Do Not Copy It Ten Times

Nothing dreadful will happen. Nothing dreadful ever has.



4



Write Back About Your Garden

Tell her about the tomatoes. Ask about her cat.

5



Tuck in a Recipe

A recipe card is a gift. Aunts love a recipe.

6



Mail It With a Smile

Drop it in the box. She will write back about her cat.

NOTES

If she sends a petition, send back a photo of the grandchildren. It is always a fair trade.

HOW TO

RIDING ALONG WITH TALK RADIO

SKILL 32 · TALKING WITHOUT FIGHTING · 1 CAR RIDE · HARD

Grandpa drives you to the ballgame, and Grandpa's car radio only gets one station. It is a long drive. Here is how to survive it and still enjoy the hot dogs.

1



Bring a Comic

Read about Superman while the radio talks about everything else.

2



Look Out the Window

Count cows. There are always cows.

3



Suggest I Spy

'I spy something red.' There will be plenty of red.

MATERIALS



A comic book



A baseball mitt



A bag of peanuts



A window to look out of



A game of I Spy

4



Crack the Peanuts

Peanuts make noise. Noise is useful.

5

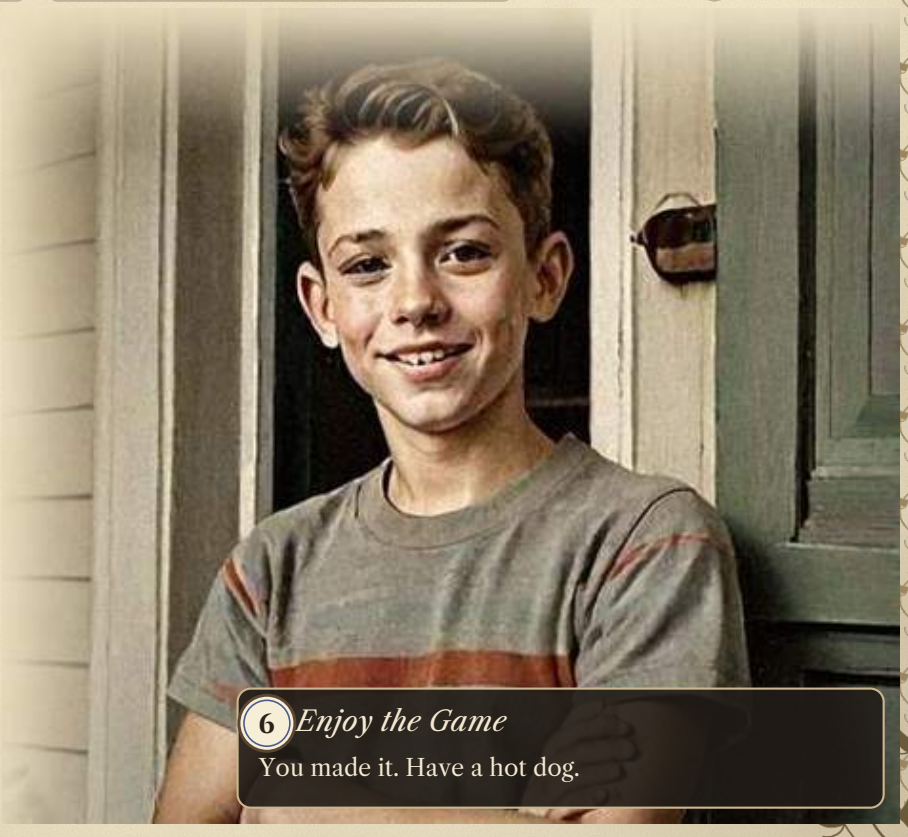


Ask About Baseball

Ask Grandpa who his favorite player was in 1938. The radio will go off.

NOTES

Ask Grandpa to teach you to whistle. It's impossible to talk and whistle at the same time.



6 *Enjoy the Game*

You made it. Have a hot dog.

HOW TO

AGREEING TO DISAGREE

SKILL 33 · TALKING WITHOUT FIGHTING · 10 MINUTES · HARD

MATERIALS

- A porch swing



- Two glasses of lemonade



- A soft cushion



- Fifty years of patience



- A good laugh



Grandma has been married to Grandpa for fifty-one years, and they have voted differently in every single election. She knows the secret.

1



Sit Down Together

Pick the porch swing. It's hard to stay cross while swinging.

2



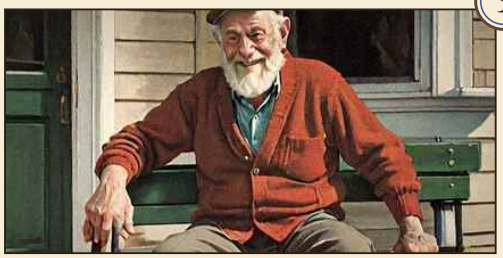
Say Your Piece Once

Say what you think, kindly and briefly. Then stop.

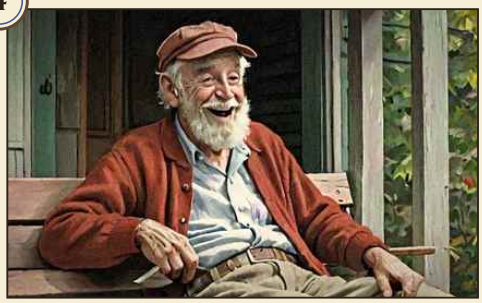
3

Let Him Say His

Let him say his, just as briefly. He will take longer. Let him.



4



Say the Magic Words

'Well, we'll just have to agree to disagree.' Then smile.

5



Pour the Lemonade

A cold drink ends a warm talk.

6



Laugh About It

Fifty-one years. It works.

NOTES

Grandma's real secret: she cancels his vote every time, and he knows it, and they both think it's funny.

HOW TO

ENDING A CONVERSATION GRACEFULLY

SKILL 34 · TALKING WITHOUT FIGHTING · 2 MINUTES · MEDIUM

Some conversations need to end. A gracious exit leaves everyone smiling and nobody wondering why you suddenly ran to the car.

1



Glance at Your Watch

A small look at your watch tells the other person time is short.

2



Say Something Kind

'It was so good to see you' is true more often than you think.

3



Mention the Oven

'I've left something in the oven' is the classic. Use it.

MATERIALS


A wristwatch


Car keys


A casserole dish to return


A kind word


A good excuse

4



Step Backward Slowly

Take one step back while still talking. Then another.

5



Jingle Your Keys

Keys in hand mean you're leaving. Everyone understands keys.

NOTES

Always have a casserole dish to return. It is the perfect reason to leave and to come back.



6 *Wave and Go*

Big wave. Big smile. Drive away.

CHAPTER SIX

6

KEEPING YOUR SPIRITS UP

Calm, cheer and a good night's sleep in uncertain times







An apocalypse is hard on the nerves, even a cheerful one with marching bands. The good news is that the old remedies still work: fresh air, a garden, a long walk, a good laugh and an early bedtime. This chapter is your prescription. Take two and call us in the morning.

IN THIS CHAPTER

35 The Ten-Breath Rule
36 Gardening Your Worries Away
37 Taking a News Fast
38 Laughing It Off
39 A Long Walk in the Woods
40 A Hot Bath and an Early Bedtime

HOW TO

THE TEN-BREATH RULE

SKILL 35 · KEEPING YOUR SPIRITS UP · 2 MINUTES · EASY

Before you answer, take ten breaths. By the tenth, you will usually have decided that the answer can wait until after supper.

1



Stop What You're Doing

Put down the spoon. Put down the newspaper. Stop.

2



Sit Down

A kitchen chair will do.

3

Breathe In Slowly

In through the nose, counting to four.



4



Breathe Out Slowly

Out through the mouth, counting to six. Do it ten times.

5



Sip Some Tea

Chamomile, if you have it. Anything warm, if you don't.

6



Carry On Smiling

Now go back to what you were doing. The world is just the same, and so are you.

NOTES

Count the breaths on your fingers. Children love to copy, and then they learn it too.

MATERIALS

- A quiet spot



- A kitchen chair



- A cup of chamomile tea



- A sunny window



- A wristwatch



HOW TO

GARDENING YOUR WORRIES AWAY

SKILL 36 · KEEPING YOUR SPIRITS UP · 1 MORNING · EASY

Nobody has ever stayed angry while pulling weeds. A garden asks only for water and sun, and it gives back tomatoes and peace of mind.

MATERIALS


Garden gloves


A trowel


A packet of seeds


A watering can


A sun hat

1



Put On Your Hat

A big straw sun hat. It's part of the treatment.

2



Pull the Weeds

Pull every weed by its roots. Imagine it is a headline.

3



Plant Some Seeds

Beans are quick and cheerful.

4



Water Everything

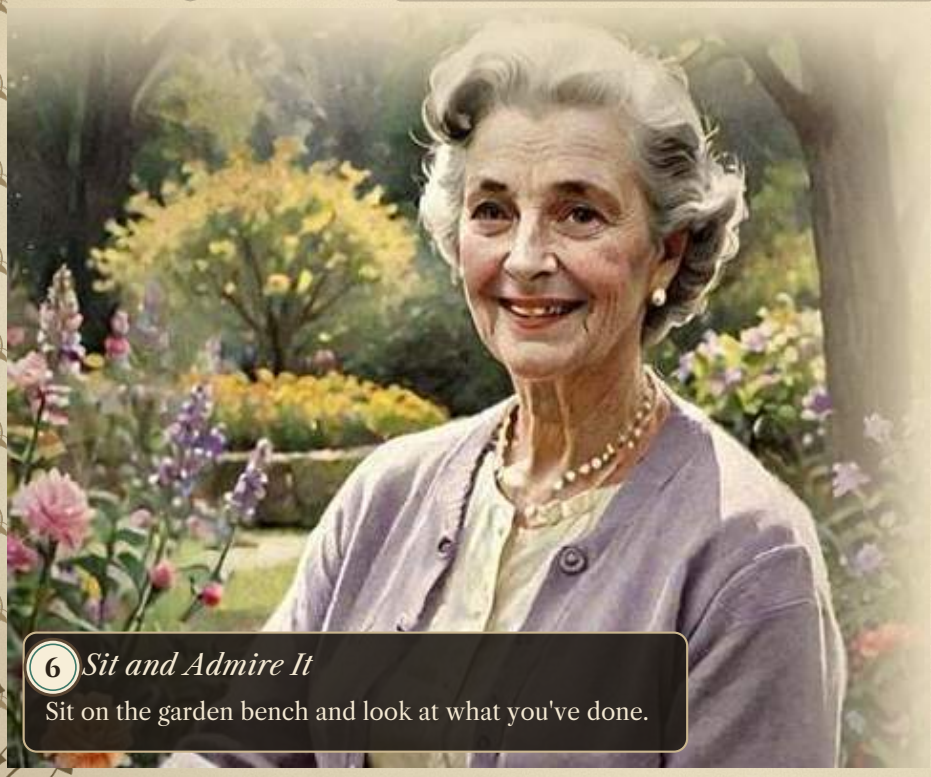
Water gently, at the roots.

5



Pick a Tomato

Eat it right there, warm from the sun.



6 *Sit and Admire It*

Sit on the garden bench and look at what you've done.

NOTES

The only red things in the garden are tomatoes. That alone is restful.

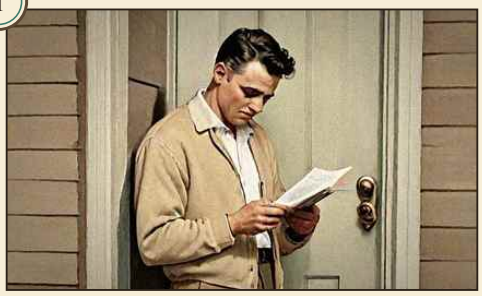
HOW TO

TAKING A NEWS FAST

SKILL 37 · KEEPING YOUR SPIRITS UP · 1 WEEK · HARD

Once in a while, a sensible father switches off the radio, cancels the paper for a week and finds out that the world goes on perfectly well without him reading about it.

1



Stop the Paper

Leave a note for the paperboy. Tip him anyway.

2



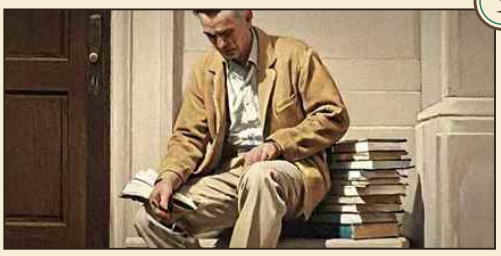
Unplug the Radio

Unplug it and put a tea towel over it, like a birdcage.

3

Visit the Library

Borrow books about anything else. Fishing. Mountains. Clocks.



4



Play Cards With the Family

Gin rummy in the evenings. Keep score.

5



Ride a Bicycle

Ride around the block. Ring the bell at everyone.

6



Peek After a Week

At the end of the week, read one headline. Then decide if you want another week.

NOTES

You will find out anything important from the barber anyway.

MATERIALS

- A note for the paperboy



- A screwdriver (for the radio knob)



- A stack of library books



- A deck of cards



- A bicycle



HOW TO

LAUGHING IT OFF

SKILL 38 · KEEPING YOUR SPIRITS UP · 10 MINUTES · EASY

Laughter is the best medicine, and it doesn't need a prescription. Children are experts, and they are happy to teach.

MATERIALS


A joke book

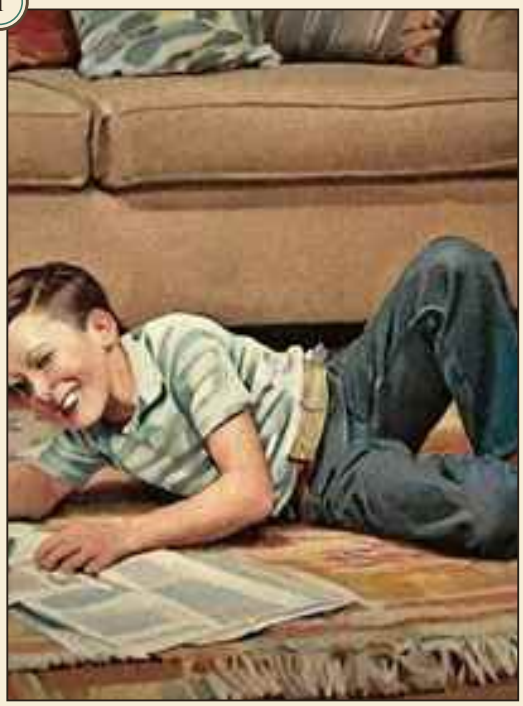

A whoopee cushion


The Sunday funnies


A rubber chicken


A mirror for silly faces

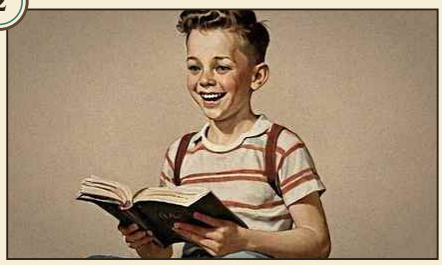
1



Read the Funnies

Start with the Sunday funnies, all of them.

2



Tell a Joke

Knock-knock jokes are best. Even grown-ups have to answer.

3



Make a Silly Face

Practice in the mirror. Then use it at supper.

4



Set Up the Whoopee Cushion

On Father's chair, of course.

5



Wave the Rubber Chicken

Nobody can stay grumpy near a rubber chicken.



6 *Laugh Until You Snort*

When everyone is laughing, the job is done.

NOTES

The rubber chicken also works on uncles.

HOW TO

A LONG WALK IN THE WOODS

SKILL 39 · KEEPING YOUR SPIRITS UP · 1 AFTERNOON · EASY

There are no signs in the forest, no flags on the pines and no loudspeakers by the creek. A long walk clears the head better than anything sold in a bottle.

1



Lace Your Boots
Good boots, double-knotted.

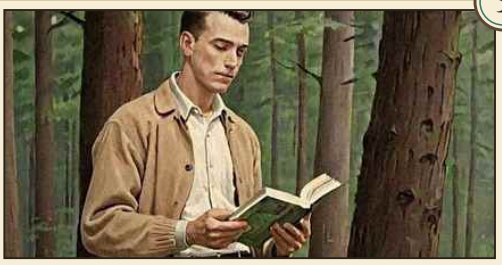
2



Find the Trail
Pick a trail you know. Walk it slowly.

3

Listen to the Birds
Stop and listen. Look them up in the book.



4



Cross the Creek
Step on the flat stones. Take your time.

5



Eat Your Sandwich
On a log, in the sun.

6



Walk Home Lighter
You'll feel ten pounds lighter, even if you ate the sandwich.

NOTES

Leave the transistor radio at home. The birds are better.

MATERIALS

- Sturdy walking boots



- A walking stick



- A canteen of water



- A sandwich



- A bird book



HOW TO

A HOT BATH AND AN EARLY BEDTIME

SKILL 40 · KEEPING YOUR SPIRITS UP · 1 EVENING · EASY

When all else fails, run a hot bath and go to bed at eight. Things look better in the morning. They nearly always do.

MATERIALS


Bubble bath


A fluffy towel


Warm pajamas


A glass of warm milk


A good book

1



Run the Bath
Hot, but not too hot. Lots of bubbles.

2



Light a Candle
One candle on the windowsill makes it special.

3



Soak
Twenty minutes. Nobody may knock.

4



Put On Warm Pajamas
Flannel ones, fresh from the drawer.

5



Drink Your Warm Milk
It really does help.



6 *Read Until You Nod Off*
A chapter or two of something gentle. Lights out by nine.

NOTES

Put your shoes by the door for the morning. Tomorrow is another day.

CHAPTER SEVEN

7

OUT AND ABOUT

The diner, the fair, the barbershop and every red cap in between







Sooner or later you must leave the house. The car needs gas, the children need shoes, and the church picnic will not attend itself. Out in town the caps are thicker than dandelions and the flags fly from every lamppost. Keep your head, keep your manners, and keep a few dimes in your pocket for the parking meter. This chapter shows you how.

IN THIS CHAPTER

41 Getting Through Rally Traffic
42 Ordering at the Red-Cap Diner
43 Checking Out at the Hardware Store
44 Visiting the County Fair
45 Enjoying the Church Picnic
46 Sitting in the Barber's Chair
47 Watching the Fourth of July Parade

HOW TO

GETTING THROUGH RALLY TRAFFIC

SKILL 41 · OUT AND ABOUT · 2 HOURS · HARD

MATERIALS

- A full tank of gas



- A road map



- A thermos of coffee



- A bag of sandwiches



- A car game for the children



When there's a rally at the fairgrounds, every road in the county fills with honking cars flying flags. You will be late. Here is how to be late cheerfully.

1



Check the Paper

Rallies are announced days ahead. Plan around them if you can.

2



Find Another Road

Study the map for back roads. Farm roads are your friend.

3

Fill the Tank

You may idle for a long time.



4



Pour the Coffee

When the line stops, pour a cup. You're not going anywhere.

5



Wave at the Flags

The fellow in the next truck is waving. Wave back.

6



Arrive and Laugh

You're two hours late. So is everyone. Laugh about it.

NOTES

The farm roads are slower but prettier, and there are cows to count.

HOW TO

ORDERING AT THE RED-CAP DINER

SKILL 42 · OUT AND ABOUT · 1 HOUR · EASY

The best diner in town is full of red caps at breakfast. The coffee is still strong, the pancakes are still fluffy and the waitress still calls everyone 'hon'.

1



Find a Booth

Take the booth by the window. It has the best light.

2



Read the Menu

The specials are on the chalkboard. The pancakes are always good.

3



Order Pancakes

Stacks of three. With extra butter.

MATERIALS


An appetite


A dime for the jukebox


Exact change


A tip for the waitress


A newspaper (sports section only)

4



Pick a Song

Put a dime in the jukebox. Pick something everyone knows.

5



Admire the Caps

Count the caps at the counter. Say good morning to the nearest.

NOTES

Nobody talks politics with their mouth full of pancakes. Order the big stack.



6 *Tip Well*

Tip the waitress generously. She has heard everything.

HOW TO

CHECKING OUT AT THE HARDWARE STORE

SKILL 43 · OUT AND ABOUT · 30 MINUTES · EASY

MATERIALS

- The broken part (in a paper bag)



- A shopping list



- Your wallet



- A friendly hello



- A tape measure



Mr. Dawson's hardware store has the best nails in town, a bumper sticker on the register and a red cap on Mr. Dawson. He still knows exactly which washer you need.

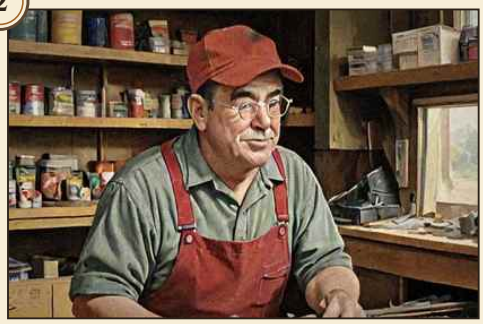
1



Bring the Broken Part

Bring the old one. Mr. Dawson can match anything.

2



Ask for Help

He loves to help. It is his favorite thing.

3

Let Him Explain

He will tell you how to fix it. Listen; he is right.



4



Notice the Sticker

There is a sticker on the register. Notice it, then notice the nails.

5



Pay and Thank Him

Thank him by name. Mention you'll be back.

6



Fix It at Home

It works. Mr. Dawson was right. He usually is about washers.

NOTES

Ask about his fishing trip. It works even better than asking about washers.

HOW TO

VISITING THE COUNTY FAIR

SKILL 44 · OUT AND ABOUT · 1 DAY · EASY

The county fair still has pie contests, prize pigs and a Ferris wheel. This year it also has a booth selling caps, shirts, flags and a life-size cardboard eagle.

1



See the Prize Pigs

Start at the livestock barn. The pigs don't vote.

2



Walk Past the Cap Booth

There will be a booth piled high with red caps. Smile and keep walking.

3



Eat Cotton Candy

Pink is a lovely color too.

MATERIALS



A ribbon for your hair



A quarter for the Ferris wheel



A bag for cotton candy



Sunscreen



Comfortable shoes

4



Ride the Ferris Wheel

From the top you can see the whole town. It looks just like it always did.

5



Watch the Pie Contest

Everyone agrees about pie.

NOTES

The cap booth gives away free stickers. Put one on your little brother.



6 *Win a Ribbon*

Enter your jam. It might win.

HOW TO

ENJOYING THE CHURCH PICNIC

SKILL 45 · OUT AND ABOUT · 1 AFTERNOON · EASY

The church picnic is where the whole town comes together, caps and all, for fried chicken, a pie table and a three-legged race. Everyone is on their best behavior. Mostly.

MATERIALS

- A basket of fried chicken



- A checked blanket



- A deviled egg platter



- Your Sunday hat



- A paper fan

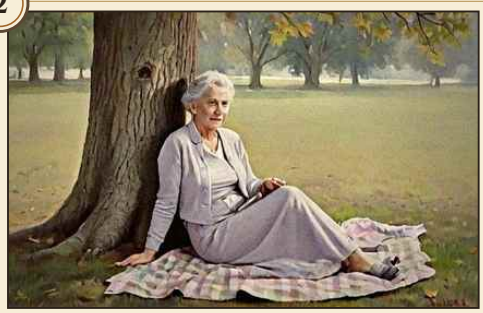


1



Bring the Chicken
Fried chicken is the ticket into any picnic.

2



Spread the Blanket
Under the oak tree, if you're early enough.

3

Set Out the Eggs
Deviled eggs vanish faster than anything.

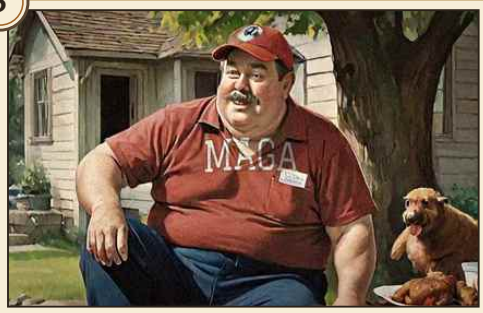


4



Say Grace
Everyone bows their head. It's the quietest moment of the year.

5



Admire the Hats
Some are Sunday hats. Some are red caps. All of them are on heads bowed in grace.

6



Fan Yourself
Sit in the shade and fan. You've earned it.

NOTES

Sit by the pie table. Everyone comes by the pie table eventually.

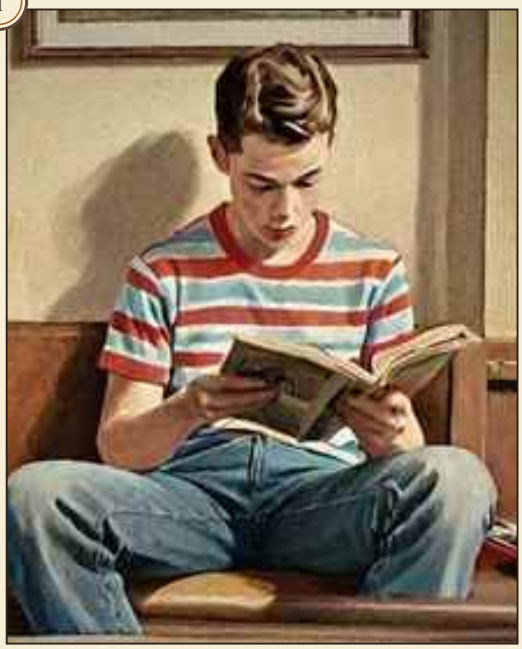
HOW TO

SITTING IN THE BARBER'S CHAIR

SKILL 46 · OUT AND ABOUT · 30 MINUTES · MEDIUM

Saturday is haircut day. The barbershop has a striped pole, a stack of comics, a radio on the shelf and four men in red caps waiting their turn. Bring a comic.

1



Wait Your Turn

Sit on the bench and read. The men will be talking. Read harder.

2



Climb Into the Chair

The big chair goes up and up.

3



Sit Very Still

Stillness is important when there are scissors.

MATERIALS


A quarter for the haircut


A comic book


A lollipop (after)


Clean ears


A brave face

4



Listen to the Barber

The barber knows everything about everybody. He wears his cap backward while he works.

5



Look in the Mirror

Admire your new haircut.

NOTES

Ask the barber about baseball. Barbers know baseball.



6 *Get Your Lollipop*

The best part.

HOW TO

WATCHING THE FOURTH OF JULY PARADE

SKILL 47 · OUT AND ABOUT · 1 MORNING · EASY

Main Street fills with marching bands, fire trucks, Shriners in tiny cars and a float with a giant papier-mache eagle in a red cap. It is wonderful. Bring a flag.

MATERIALS

- A small American flag



- A spot on the curb



- A bag for candy



- A sun hat



- Earmuffs (for the drums)



1



Get There Early
The best curb spots go by eight.

2



Hear the Band
The marching band comes first. Feel the drums in your tummy.

3

Catch the Candy
Hold out your bag. Firemen throw candy.



4



Admire the Eagle Float
It is very big and very proud. Clap.

5



Wave Your Flag
Everyone waves the same flag on the Fourth. Remember that.

6



Walk Home Happy
Carry your flag and your candy home.

NOTES

On the Fourth, every cap in town is cheering for the same thing: fireworks.

CHAPTER EIGHT

8

UNUSUAL SITUATIONS

For the days when things get a little bit crazy







Most of the apocalypse is ordinary: caps, flags and honking. But now and then something happens that no sensible family could have planned for. The dog comes home in a bandana. Grandpa joins a tractor convoy. A twenty-foot inflatable appears next door overnight. This chapter is for those days. Keep calm, keep your camera handy and remember that it will make a wonderful story at Thanksgiving.

IN THIS CHAPTER

48 When the Dog Comes Home in a MAGA Bandana
49 When Grandpa Joins a Tractor Convoy
50 Winning a Signed Cap in the Church Raffle
51 When Your Nephew Wears the Cap to School
52 The Giant Inflatable Next Door
53 When a Big Rally Comes to Town
54 When a Red Cap Blows into Your Yard

HOW TO

WHEN THE DOG COMES HOME IN A MAGA BANDANA

SKILL 48 · UNUSUAL SITUATIONS · 10 MINUTES · EASY

The neighbor loves your dog, and your dog loves the neighbor's treats. One afternoon Rusty trots home wearing a red bandana with white letters. He looks very proud.

MATERIALS


A dog brush


A spare blue bandana


Dog biscuits


A camera


A good laugh

1



Notice the Bandana

It is hard to miss. It is very red.

2



Do Not Scold Him

Rusty did nothing wrong. He just likes treats.

3



Take a Picture

Dad will want to see this.

4



Swap the Bandana

Untie it gently and tie on a blue one. Rusty doesn't mind either way.

5



Return the Red One

Fold it neatly and take it back next door with a thank-you.



6 *Give Him a Biscuit*

Rusty is a good boy, whatever he wears.

NOTES

Dogs are not political. They are treat-ical.

HOW TO

WHEN GRANDPA JOINS A TRACTOR CONVOY

SKILL 49 · UNUSUAL SITUATIONS · 1 DAY · MEDIUM

Grandpa has a red tractor, a red cap and an invitation to drive in the Saturday tractor convoy. He will be gone all day. Pack him a lunch.

1



Polish the Tractor

He'll want it shining.

2



Tie On the Flag

Grandpa has three flags. Help him tie them on.

3

Pack His Lunch

Ham sandwich, apple, cookies. And a cushion.



4



Wave Him Off

He will drive at six miles an hour. Wave for a long time.

5



Watch the Convoy

Forty tractors in a line, flags flying. It is quite a sight.

6



Welcome Him Home

He'll be sunburned and very happy. Have supper ready.

NOTES

Ask him to drive you to the ice-cream stand next week. Tractors are great for ice cream.

MATERIALS

- A packed lunch



- A thermos of coffee



- A cushion for the tractor seat



- A spare flag



- A camera



HOW TO

WINNING A SIGNED CAP IN THE CHURCH RAFFLE

SKILL 50 · UNUSUAL SITUATIONS · 1 EVENING · EASY

You bought one raffle ticket to support the new church roof. The prize was a casserole dish. You won the second prize instead: a signed red cap in a glass case.

MATERIALS


Your raffle ticket


A gracious smile


A spare shelf


A thank-you note


A box for the trip home

1



Hear Your Number

They call your number. Everyone turns to look.

2



Walk Up Gracefully

Smile, walk up and accept the prize. Shake the pastor's hand.

3



Hold It Up

Hold it up so everyone can see. They will cheer. Some of them very loudly.

4



Carry It Home

Carry it carefully. It is worth more than the casserole dish.

5



Find It a Shelf

Put it in the hall closet. Or on Uncle Earl's birthday list.



6 *Write a Thank-You*

Thank the raffle committee. The roof needed fixing.

NOTES

Uncle Earl's birthday is in March. You now have his present.

HOW TO

WHEN YOUR NEPHEW WEARS THE CAP TO SCHOOL

SKILL 51 · UNUSUAL SITUATIONS · 1 SCHOOL DAY · MEDIUM

Your sister's boy has decided to wear his red cap and letterman jacket to high school every day. He is sixteen, he is proud, and he will absolutely grow out of something by Christmas.

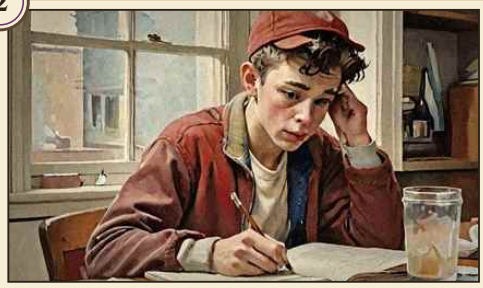
1



Admire His Spirit

He is passionate. That is a good thing in a young man.

2



Check the Homework

Ask if his algebra is done. Caps don't do algebra.

3

Pack His Lunch

Peanut butter and jelly, an apple, a cookie.



4



Drive Him to School

Drop him at the front steps. He'll ask you to drop him around the corner.

5



Hear About His Day

Ask about his day. He'll mostly talk about football.

6



Remember Being Sixteen

You had your own ideas at sixteen. Your parents survived.

NOTES

He'll want to be a lawyer, a cowboy and an astronaut by Easter. Encourage all three.

MATERIALS

- A packed lunch



- A pencil case



- His algebra homework



- A ride to school



- A cool head



HOW TO

THE GIANT INFLATABLE NEXT DOOR

SKILL 52 · UNUSUAL SITUATIONS · 1 MORNING · MEDIUM

You wake up and look out the window. There is a thirty-foot inflatable eagle in the neighbor's yard, wearing a red cap and swaying gently in the breeze. It was not there last night.

MATERIALS


Your coffee


A camera


A pair of binoculars


Rope (in case of wind)


A neighborly attitude

1



Look Out the Window

Look twice. It is still there.

2



Step Outside

Go out in your robe. Everyone else on the street is out in theirs.

3



Take It In

It is very big. It has a cap. It sways.

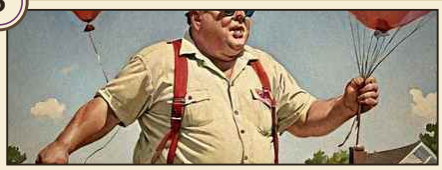
4



Take a Picture

Nobody at the office will believe you.

5



Help in the Wind

When the wind picks up, help tie it down. It's the neighborly thing.



6 *Enjoy It at Night*

At night it glows. The children love it.

NOTES

If it blows away, it will land on the school roof. It always lands on the school roof.

HOW TO

WHEN A BIG RALLY COMES TO TOWN

SKILL 53 · UNUSUAL SITUATIONS · 1 WEEKEND · HARD

Once a year a big rally comes to the fairgrounds. Thousands of red caps, marching bands, hot dog stands and a lot of very happy honking. Your neighbor has front-row tickets.

1



Shop Early

The grocery store will be full of visitors by Friday. Shop Thursday.

2



Wave Off Your Neighbor

He'll leave at dawn with a cooler and three flags.

3

Close the Windows

The cheering can be heard from the fairgrounds.



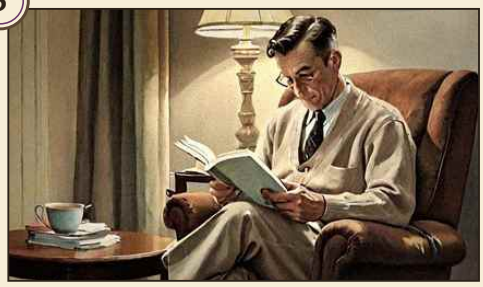
4



Watch the Fireworks

There are always fireworks. Fireworks are fun for everyone.

5



Read a Good Book

Stay home with something long and gentle.

6



Welcome Him Home

He'll come home hoarse and happy. Bring him a lemonade.

NOTES

Rally weekend is the best time to go fishing. Every lake in the county is empty.

MATERIALS

- Earplugs



- A full pantry



- A good book



- Groceries bought in advance



- A neighborly wave



HOW TO

WHEN A RED CAP BLOWS INTO YOUR YARD

SKILL 54 · UNUSUAL SITUATIONS · 10 MINUTES · EASY

On a windy day a red cap sails over the fence and lands in your tomato patch. Somebody, somewhere, is looking for it. Do the right thing.

MATERIALS


A long-handled rake


Clean hands


A kind note


A paper bag


Good manners

1



See It Land

It will land in the worst possible place. Usually the tomatoes.

2



Fish It Out

Use the rake if it's out of reach.

3



Brush It Off

Brush off the dirt. Tomato stains come out with soap.

4



Find the Owner

Look over the fence. Somebody will be looking very sad.

5



Hand It Back

Hand it over the fence. He will be very grateful.



6 *Accept a Thank-You*

You may get a cookie. You may get a sticker. Accept the cookie.

NOTES

Doing the right thing is always in style, whatever hat you're wearing.

CHAPTER NINE

9

REBUILDING TOGETHER

After the honking stops: fences, potlucks and handshakes







Here is the secret of every apocalypse: it ends. The signs come down, the boats go back in the boathouse and the flags are folded for next time. And the neighbors are still the neighbors. The same man in the red cap will help you shovel your drive in January, and you will bring him soup when he has the flu. This last chapter is about building the street back up, together.

IN THIS CHAPTER

55 Hosting the Everybody Potluck
56 Fixing the Fence with the Neighbor
57 Holding a Pie Contest Truce
58 Watching the Ball Game Together
59 Sharing a Fourth of July Picnic
60 The Handshake Over the Fence

HOW TO

HOSTING THE EVERYBODY POTLUCK

SKILL 55 · REBUILDING TOGETHER · 1 AFTERNOON · MEDIUM

Invite the whole street, red caps and all, to a potluck on the lawn. Everyone brings a dish, nobody brings a sign, and there is enough food for an army.

MATERIALS

- Long folding tables



- Invitations for every house



- A big pitcher of lemonade



- Paper plates and napkins



- A blackboard sign: 'All Welcome'



1



Write the Invitations

One for every house on the street. Yes, that one too.

2



Deliver Them by Hand

Knock and hand them over personally. It's harder to say no to a face.

3

Set Up the Tables

Long tables on the lawn with checked cloths.



4



Welcome Everyone

Stand at the gate and greet each family.

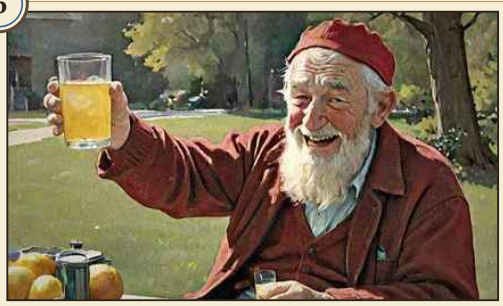
5



Taste Everything

Try every dish. Compliment every cook.

6



Toast the Street

Raise a glass of lemonade to the neighborhood.

NOTES

Put the dessert table in the middle. Everyone will end up standing there together.

HOW TO

FIXING THE FENCE WITH THE NEIGHBOR

SKILL 56 · REBUILDING TOGETHER · 1 SATURDAY · MEDIUM

The old fence between your yards is falling down. It belongs to both of you. Fixing it together is the best afternoon two neighbors can spend.

1



Knock on His Door

Ask if he has a Saturday free. He'll bring his own hammer.

2



Pull Out the Old Boards

Work from each end toward the middle.

3



Nail Up the New Ones

Measure twice. He'll want to measure three times.

MATERIALS


New fence boards


A hammer each


A box of nails


A bucket of white paint


Two cold sodas

4



Take a Soda Break

Lean on the fence and drink a soda. Talk about lawns.

5



Paint It White

White paint, both sides. No arguments about color.

NOTES

He gets to paint his side red if he wants. It's his side.



6 *Admire Your Work*

A good fence, shared.

HOW TO

HOLDING A PIE CONTEST TRUCE

SKILL 57 · REBUILDING TOGETHER · 1 AFTERNOON · MEDIUM

Grandma and Aunt Darlene have argued about everything since 1948. But both make magnificent pies. A friendly pie contest settles nothing and pleases everybody.

MATERIALS

- Two pies (at least)



- A judge with no opinions



- Blue ribbons



- Forks for everyone



- A pitcher of milk



1



Announce the Contest

Pin a notice to the church board.

2



Bake Your Best

Each baker bakes her best.

3

Find a Judge

Pick the pastor. He has no opinions about anything but pie.



4



Taste Them Both

One forkful each. Then another to be sure.

5



Declare a Tie

It's always a tie. Everybody gets a ribbon.

6



Share the Pies

Cut both pies and pass them round. Everybody wins.

NOTES

Next year, have them bake one pie together. That's the real contest.

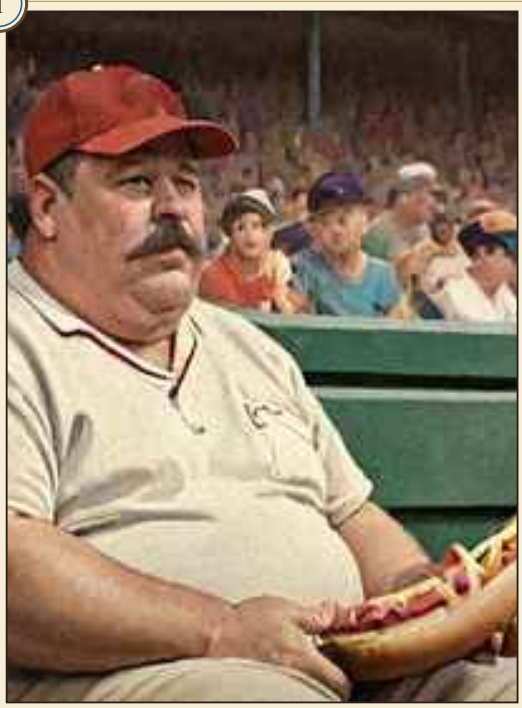
HOW TO

WATCHING THE BALL GAME TOGETHER

SKILL 58 · REBUILDING TOGETHER · 3 HOURS · EASY

Whatever cap he wears to the ballpark, Uncle Earl cheers for the same team you do. For nine innings, there's only one side.

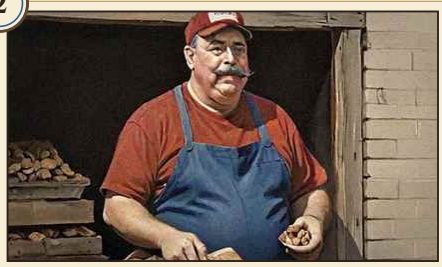
1



Get Good Seats

Behind first base, in the sun.

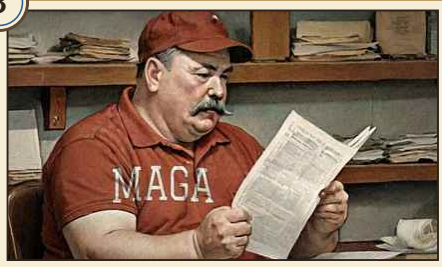
2



Buy Peanuts

Peanuts for both of you. He'll buy the second bag.

3



Keep Score

He'll teach you the scorecard. He keeps it perfectly.

MATERIALS



Two tickets



Peanuts and Cracker Jack



A baseball mitt



A pencil and scorecard



Sunscreen

4



Sing in the Seventh

Stand up and sing. Everyone sings the same words.

5



Cheer the Home Run

Jump up and shout together.

NOTES

Buy him a team cap at the stand. He might even wear it. Over the other one.



6 *Talk It Over on the Way Home*

You'll talk baseball all the way home. Nothing else.

HOW TO

SHARING A FOURTH OF JULY PICNIC

SKILL 59 · REBUILDING TOGETHER · 1 DAY · EASY

On the Fourth of July, every flag on the street is the same flag. Fire up the grill, set out the watermelon and invite everybody over for fireworks.

MATERIALS

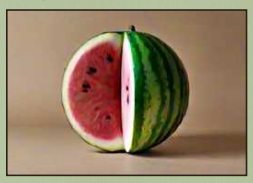
- A charcoal grill



- Hamburgers and hot dogs



- A big watermelon



- Sparklers



- A blanket for fireworks



1



Hang the Bunting

Red, white and blue across the porch. Everyone's colors.

2



Fire Up the Grill

Charcoal, a match, and patience.

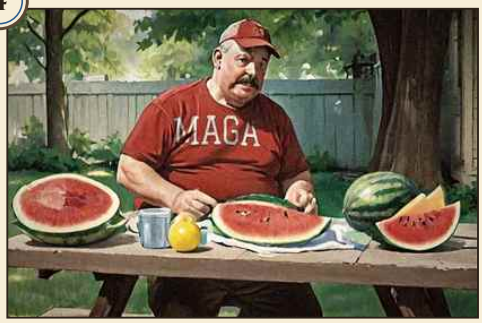
3

Grill the Burgers

Flip them once. Only once.



4



Cut the Watermelon

Big slices for everyone.

5



Light the Sparklers

Light them for the children and watch their faces.

6



Watch the Fireworks

Lie on the blanket and watch. Everyone says 'ooh' together.

NOTES

Fireworks are the one thing both parties agree should be bigger.

HOW TO

THE HANDSHAKE OVER THE FENCE

SKILL 60 · REBUILDING TOGETHER · 1 MINUTE · EASY

The last skill in this book is the shortest and the most important. Walk to the fence, put out your hand and say 'Good morning, neighbor'. That's how every apocalypse ends.

1



Walk to the Fence

Leave your opinions on the porch. You can pick them up later.

2



Wait for Him to Look Up

He's watering his roses. Wait a moment.

3



Say Good Morning

The two most important words in the neighborhood.

MATERIALS



A fence



A neighbor



An open hand



A good morning



Nothing else

4



Put Out Your Hand

Firm grip, look him in the eye.

5



Talk About the Roses

They really are very fine roses.



6 *Walk Back Smiling*

That's it. That's how you survive. Same time tomorrow.

NOTES

Do it again tomorrow. Neighbors are made one morning at a time.

APPENDIX

Charts, checklists and quick references

A. FIELD GUIDE TO THE GEAR

What you are likely to see, where you will see it, and the friendliest response. Sightings increase sharply every fourth autumn.

GEAR	WHERE SEEN	HOW COMMON	WEARER'S MOOD	WHAT TO DO
Red cap	Everywhere	Very	Cheerful	Smile and nod
Red tee shirt	Barbecues, diners	Very	Hungry	Pass the mustard
Campaign pins	Cardigans, lapels	Common	Proud	Admire one pin
Porch flag	Front porches	Common	Patriotic	Wave
Truck flags	Pickup trucks	Common	Honking	Wave back
Knitted sweater	Christmas	Seasonal	Festive	Say 'Oh my!'
Inflatable eagle	Front lawns	Rare	Very festive	Take a photograph
Boat flag	Lakes, summer	Seasonal	Splashy	Stand back
Dog bandana	Your dog	Rare	Waggy	Give a biscuit

B. FAMILY GATHERINGS CHART

Plan ahead for every holiday. Times are for an average family; add an hour if Uncle Earl brings his photographs.

GATHERING	CAPS EXPECTED	BRING	SAFE TOPIC	LEAVE BY
Thanksgiving	Most of them	Two pies	Football	After pie
Christmas	Knitted ones	Eggnog	The tree	After carols
Fourth of July	Plenty	Watermelon	Fireworks	After fireworks
Church picnic	Some	Fried chicken	The weather	After grace
Block party	Lots	Potato salad	The lawns	Dusk
Ball game	A few	Peanuts	Baseball	Ninth inning
Sunday supper	Grandpa's	Rolls	The grandchildren	Before the news

C. CHECKLISTS

Copy these pages and tick items off as you get ready. Check the pie supply and the earmuffs every week.

APOCALYPSE SURVIVAL KIT

- ☐ Earmuffs for every family member
- ☐ A full comfort pantry (see Chapter 2)
- ☐ Thick curtains
- ☐ A radio that only gets ball games
- ☐ The makings of an emergency pie
- ☐ A deck of cards and a crossword
- ☐ A folding lawn chair for parades
- ☐ A farmers' almanac (for weather talk)
- ☐ A casserole dish to return
- ☐ A small American flag to wave
- ☐ Chamomile tea
- ☐ A good sense of humor

THANKSGIVING GO-BAG

- ☐ Two pies
- ☐ A seating chart
- ☐ Extra chairs
- ☐ The football schedule
- ☐ A list of safe topics (see Appendix D)
- ☐ Leftover containers
- ☐ A kitchen timer (for escapes)
- ☐ A wristwatch
- ☐ Car keys, easy to reach
- ☐ Patience, doubled

BEFORE UNCLE EARL VISITS

- ☐ Bake his favorite pie
- ☐ Hide the newspaper
- ☐ Tune the radio to the ball game
- ☐ Set out a hat hook (he won't use it)
- ☐ Ask about his sweet potatoes
- ☐ Plan a fishing trip
- ☐ Practice the polite nod
- ☐ Have the photo albums ready
- ☐ Remember: he fixed your gutter

D. DINNER-TABLE TOPICS: SAFE OR NOT?

When in doubt, talk about the weather. If someone brings up a topic from the 'No' list, see Changing the Subject in Chapter 5 and pass the gravy.

DINNER-TABLE TOPIC	SAFE?	NOTES
The weather	Yes	The classic; never fails
Baseball	Yes	Unless they root for the Yankees
Pie	Yes	Everyone has a favorite
The grandchildren	Yes	Bring photographs
Fishing	Yes	Stories get bigger each year
Gardening	Yes	Tomatoes are neutral
Lawn care	Mostly	Avoid the subject of signs
Gas prices	Careful	Leads to Washington in two steps
The newspaper	No	Leads to Washington in one step
Washington	No	See above
Anyone's hat	No	Compliment it or say nothing
'Well, actually...'	Never	Those words have ended marriages

E. HANDY APOCALYPSE CONVERSIONS

MEASURE	ROUGHLY EQUALS
1 boat parade	3 hours of honking
1 truck convoy	40 pickups, 120 flags
1 uncle at Thanksgiving	2 pies and a long story
1 lawn sign	Grows into 30 by October
1 tall flagpole	Shade for half a tomato patch
1 inflatable eagle	30 feet, 1 cap, much swaying
1 polite nod	About 45 minutes of listening
1 change of subject	4 seconds, if done correctly
1 slice of pie	Ends 1 argument
1 whole pie	Ends a feud
1 handshake over the fence	Priceless

F. FAMILY SURVIVAL CARD

Fill this in together and pin a copy by the telephone and inside the pantry door.

Family name	
Date the first cap was spotted	
Flags on our street (count)	
Our safe topic	
Our emergency pie	
Our bunker is in the	
Earmuffs are kept in	
Uncle Earl's favorite dish	
Neighbor who fixed the gutter	
Our polite-nod champion	
Next potluck date	
Days until November	

IMPORTANT NUMBERS

Emergency	911
Bakery (for pie emergencies)	
Uncle Earl	
Aunt Darlene	
The hardware store	
The church hall	
Neighbor (red cap)	
Neighbor (no cap)	

G. GLOSSARY

Agree to disagree. An old and honorable way to end an argument with everyone still friends.

Bunker. A basement or rec room made cozy for riding out a loud election season.

Bunting. Red, white and blue cloth hung along porches. Belongs to everybody.

Common ground. Anything both sides enjoy: pie, baseball, fishing, the grandchildren.

Convoy. A long line of pickup trucks or tractors flying flags and honking.

Emergency pie. A pie baked for no reason other than that the day needed one.

Flagpole. A tall pole for flying flags. Height varies with enthusiasm.

GOP. Grand Old Party, a nickname for the Republican Party, which has been around since 1854.

MAGA. Short for 'Make America Great Again', the four words on the red cap.

News fast. A week without the newspaper or radio news. Highly recommended.

Party line. A shared telephone line. Also, what everybody in the family follows.

Polite nod. A single slow nod meaning 'I hear you'. Not to be confused with two nods.

Potluck. A meal where everyone brings a dish. The best invention in American history.

Rally. A big, loud, cheerful gathering at the fairgrounds. Go fishing that weekend.

Red cap. A red baseball cap with white lettering. Rarely removed, even indoors.

Truce. A pause in hostilities, usually arranged over pie.

Uncle Earl. Every family has one. Loud, kind, and makes excellent sweet potatoes.

Yard sign. A cardboard sign on a stake. Breeds rapidly in autumn.

H. WHERE TO LEARN MORE

- **How government works:** your public library has plain, friendly books on the Constitution, Congress and elections. Read one together.
- **Meeting your neighbors:** church suppers, block parties and the volunteer fire department pancake breakfast. Go to all of them.
- **Talking it through:** many towns have library discussion groups where people who disagree meet over coffee. They are calmer than you'd think.
- **Voting:** your county clerk's office will tell you where and when. Whatever your hat, go and vote.
- **Pie:** the cookbook shelf at your public library. Bring a wagon.

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MY SKILLS LOG

Tick off each skill once your family has done it. Uncles may not tick their own boxes.

#	SKILL	DATE TRIED	DONE
01	Spotting the First Red Cap		☐
02	Counting the Flags on Your Street		☐
03	Decoding Bumper Stickers		☐
04	Telling a MAGA Cap from a Baseball Cap		☐
05	Surviving the First Boat Parade		☐
06	Staying Calm When the Neighbor Raises a Flagpole		☐
07	Stocking the Comfort Pantry		☐
08	Turning the Rec Room into a Bunker		☐
09	Soundproofing Against the Neighbor's Loudspeaker		☐
10	Reading the Morning Paper Safely		☐
11	Baking Emergency Pie		☐
12	Making a Calm-Down Corner		☐
13	Hanging Curtains Thick Enough		☐
14	Growing a Privacy Hedge		☐
15	Borrowing Sugar from the MAGA Neighbor		☐
16	Surviving the Lawn Sign Race		☐
17	Watching the Golf Cart Parade		☐
18	Admiring the Neighbor's Patriotic Mailbox		☐
19	Enjoying the Block Party		☐
20	Surviving the Homeowners' Meeting		☐
21	Waving Back at the Truck Convoy		☐
22	Thanksgiving with Uncle Earl		☐
23	When Grandpa Gets a New Red Cap		☐
24	Surviving the Christmas Sweater Swap		☐
25	Seating the Holiday Table		☐
26	The Family Party-Line Telephone Call		☐
27	Explaining It to the Children		☐
28	Changing the Subject to the Weather		☐
29	Mastering the Polite Nod		☐
30	Finding Common Ground		☐
31	Answering Aunt Darlene's Chain Letter		☐
32	Riding Along with Talk Radio		☐
33	Agreeing to Disagree		☐
34	Ending a Conversation Gracefully		☐
35	The Ten-Breath Rule		☐
36	Gardening Your Worries Away		☐
37	Taking a News Fast		☐
38	Laughing It Off		☐

#	SKILL	DATE TRIED	DONE
39	A Long Walk in the Woods		☐
40	A Hot Bath and an Early Bedtime		☐
41	Getting Through Rally Traffic		☐
42	Ordering at the Red-Cap Diner		☐
43	Checking Out at the Hardware Store		☐
44	Visiting the County Fair		☐
45	Enjoying the Church Picnic		☐
46	Sitting in the Barber's Chair		☐
47	Watching the Fourth of July Parade		☐
48	When the Dog Comes Home in a MAGA Bandana		☐
49	When Grandpa Joins a Tractor Convoy		☐
50	Winning a Signed Cap in the Church Raffle		☐
51	When Your Nephew Wears the Cap to School		☐
52	The Giant Inflatable Next Door		☐
53	When a Big Rally Comes to Town		☐
54	When a Red Cap Blows into Your Yard		☐
55	Hosting the Everybody Potluck		☐
56	Fixing the Fence with the Neighbor		☐
57	Holding a Pie Contest Truce		☐
58	Watching the Ball Game Together		☐
59	Sharing a Fourth of July Picnic		☐
60	The Handshake Over the Fence		☐

NOTES

Flags counted, pies baked, subjects changed, and things you will never say at Thanksgiving again.

THE BOOK EVERY AMERICAN FAMILY NEEDS

It starts with one red cap across the street. By suppertime there are flags on every porch, a boat parade on the lake and Uncle Earl on the telephone. Every four years more American families wake up in a sea of red caps, and almost none of them know what to do next.

How to Survive a GOP Apocalypse is here to help: sixty sensible skills, each laid out on a single page with a picture for every step, a materials panel and notes on what can go wrong. Tabs on every page help you find what you need, even while a truck convoy honks past the window.

INSIDE YOU WILL LEARN HOW TO

- Spot the first red cap at fifty yards
- Survive Thanksgiving with Uncle Earl
- Turn the rec room into a bunker
- Bake an emergency pie
- Change the subject to the weather
- Master the polite nod
- Ride out a boat parade
- Get through rally traffic
- Live next to a giant inflatable eagle
- Shake hands over the fence



"A slice of pie has ended more feuds than any speech."

OLD FRONT-PORCH SAYING

HOW TO SURVIVE A GOP APOCALYPSE

Family / Politics (Mild) / Humor

FUN BOOKS · HOME EDITION